

American Indian Stories, Legends, and Other Writings

Study Guide by Course Hero

What's Inside

Book Basics 1

In Context 1

Author Biography 3

Characters 4

Plot Summary 6

Chapter Summaries 8

Quotes 32

Symbols 34

Themes 34

Book Basics

AUTHOR

Zitkala-Ša

YEARS PUBLISHED

c. 1896–1921

GENRE

Mythology, Nonfiction, Women's Studies

AT A GLANCE

Zitkala-Ša's collected works in *American Indian Stories, Legends, and Other Writings* demonstrate the huge breadth and style of work the author produced in her lifetime. From early speeches as an impassioned college student to her later articles calling for political reform, Zitkala-Ša demonstrates a deep understanding of her culture and its changing status. Her collection of poetry and prose, both fiction and nonfiction, reveals much about the situation of Native Americans in the early 20th century, coming at a time when the Yankton Sioux were experiencing new forms of colonialism (i.e., boarding schools and privatized land). She relates legends she loved hearing as a child and tells of her experiences living with her mother in a tepee, then attending boarding school, and later as a college student and teacher. She opens windows into her life within and outside of the Dakota culture.

PERSPECTIVE AND NARRATOR

Most of Zitkala-Ša's stories and essays in *American Indian Stories, Legends, and Other Writings* are written in the first person, with Zitkala-Ša as the primary narrator. She writes her legends and poems in third person.

TENSE

In *American Indian Stories, Legends, and Other Writings*, Zitkala-Ša's fiction—legends, stories, and poetry—is written in the past tense. Her essays and political commentary are written mostly in the present tense, with use of past tense when recounting past events.

ABOUT THE TITLE

The title *American Indian Stories, Legends, and Other Writings* describes the content of the collection. It is a mix of fictional and autobiographical stories, traditional legends, poems, and nonfiction magazine articles, political commentary, letters, speeches, and reports.

In Context

Early Native American

Literature

In the late 19th century, Native American authors struggled to have their works published and accepted by an often hostile audience. They also had to contend with the politics of the American literary tradition, which often romanticized the genocide of Native Americans or, at best, exoticized their cultures. Many of these early Native American writings in English were autobiographical works or protest literature. However, a few authors such as Ojibwa author George Copway (1818–69) tended toward assimilation, perhaps seeking ways to help their people survive in a quickly changing world or claiming legitimacy in the eyes of the Anglophone community.

Writers like George Copway and Sauk leader Black Hawk (1767–1838) managed to publish autobiographical works and gain some recognition. Copway converted to Christianity and generally supported the conversion of indigenous people. In contrast, Black Hawk's autobiography took a thoroughly antagonistic and defiant view of white culture and religion. Cherokee poet, essayist, and novelist John Rollin Ridge (1827–67) and Muskogee author and teacher S. Alice Callahan (1868–94) were the first Native Americans to write and publish novels. Zitkala-Ša was a writer whose work crossed a spectrum of genres. She wrote fiction, legend, autobiography, poetry, and essays. Much of her nonfiction sought to educate both Native Americans and white Americans about the situation faced by Native Americans and what should be done about it.

These authors were the predecessors to the period of Native American literature known as the Native American Renaissance. Writers such as Zitkala-Ša had a tremendous influence on the widely recognized Native American writers and artists of the 1960s onward. Zitkala-Ša's focus on the Native American identity and her promotion of pride in that heritage are reflected in the writers that came after her. Long after her death, other Native American writers—particularly indigenous women—have been influenced by Zitkala-Ša's writing and its insistence on the value of indigenous culture. More than 50 years later, authors such as Leslie Marmon Silko (b. 1948) tackled many of the same issues that Zitkala-Ša addresses in her work.

Colonialism

Beginning in the 15th century, the seafaring European powers began to explore and conquer large areas of the world, particularly in Africa and the Americas. From the 16th through the early 20th centuries, they established and maintained settlements called colonies, hence the name *colonialism* for this political and economic system. Economically, the colony supplies the colonizing nation with extractable resources, cheap labor, and new markets. Politically, the colony becomes part of the colonizer's empire. In her essays and stories, Zitkala-Ša deals with the effects of colonization on indigenous Americans, which included genocide, forced relocation, and forced assimilation, leading to cultural alienation.

Colonization is also a process of destruction of the local cultures and identities, also called cultural genocide. The colonized people are viewed as inferior to the colonizers. The only way for the colonized person to be perceived as "elevated," wrote Martinican anticolonial theorist Frantz Fanon (1925–61), is through "adoption of the mother country's cultural standards." This process is called assimilation. Much of Zitkala-Ša's work reflects the struggle against the effects of an assimilationist government. Zitkala-Ša herself suffered the "whitewashing" she had to undergo at boarding school, where she was forced to cut her hair and dress in the style of white Americans. She later worked at Carlisle Industrial Indian School, run by educator Richard Henry Pratt (1840–1924), famous for the statement "Kill the Indian in him, and save the man." By this, Pratt meant all traces of Indian culture must be wiped out to allegedly save the Indian people—*save* meaning "make them like their colonizers." Zitkala-Ša eventually left the school, unable to accept its harsh discipline and pressure to assimilate.

Native Americans in the 19th Century

In the 19th century, the effects of colonization caused great changes in the demographics and culture of Native Americans. Natives had already been killed in large numbers by colonial violence and diseases. In 1830 Congress passed the Indian Removal Act, which legally allowed the U.S. government to force the removal and resettlement of Eastern tribes. These tribes were removed from their desirable lands to the Western

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

prairielands, which had yet to be settled. Many tribes, including the Cherokee of the southeastern United States and the Seminole of Florida, refused to move from their ancestral lands and were forcibly removed. As many as a quarter of the displaced southeastern Native Americans died in this upheaval, part of which is now known as the "Trail of Tears." Zitkala-Ša's mother laments the death of her daughter who was ill at the time they were forced to leave and consequently died on the journey.

Most of the conflicts between Native Americans and settlers or soldiers took place when Native Americans resisted forced resettlement. In the Battle of the Little Bighorn (1876), one of the more famous of these conflicts, General George Armstrong Custer (1839–76) intended to kill or capture every person in a combined Cheyenne and Sioux camp. The warriors from these tribes, led by Sitting Bull (c. 1831–90), defended their families, and Custer's forces were slaughtered. Although only combatants were killed, the battle received wide press, and the Native Americans were portrayed negatively. In 1890 the U.S. Cavalry surrounded and slaughtered a peaceful Sioux camp at Wounded Knee. The Sioux surrendered but were massacred when soldiers opened fire on them, killing everyone. Many were women and children. By the end of the 19th century, fewer than 250,000 Native Americans remained of the estimated 5–15 million at the time of Christopher Columbus's (1451–1506) arrival in 1492.

Boarding schools created in the late 19th and early 20th centuries were part of a widespread assimilation movement that sought to integrate indigenous peoples into white society, thus stripping them of their sovereignty and culture. The federal government sent Native children to these government-sponsored boarding schools, where they experienced some of the worst effects of assimilation. The schools required children to convert to Christianity, wear uniforms, and cut their hair. The schools were also known for harsh, often physical punishment for any displays of Native American culture, such as language, dance, or song. Many students died, and survivors have described inadequate medical care, food scarcity, and pervasive physical and sexual abuse. Students and their families had little recourse against appalling conditions or abuse because the schools' primary goal was to eradicate indigenous culture through discrimination. Zitkala-Ša initially taught at one of the more notorious of these schools, Carlisle Indian Industrial School, but she eventually left because of conflicts with the school's headmaster. Many of these schools remained open and largely unchanged into the 1980s.

Author Biography

Early Life

Zitkala-Ša was born Gertrude Simmons on February 22, 1876, on the Pine Ridge reservation in South Dakota. The name Zitkala-Ša means "Red Bird." The daughter of a white father and a Yankton Sioux mother, Zitkala-Ša lived with her mother on the reservation. When Zitkala-Ša was eight, she was taken by Quaker missionaries to boarding school in Indiana. She details some of those experiences in *American Indian Stories*. She had conflicting feelings about boarding school, where she learned to read, write, and play the violin but was also forced to sacrifice her cultural heritage and adopt Quakerism (Christian belief based on self-directed discovery of God). She returned to the reservation but, feeling she no longer belonged there, left again to pursue her studies. After attending the Santee Normal Training School, she did not return permanently to the reservation. Instead in 1895 she enrolled at Earlham College, a Quaker institution in Indiana, on a scholarship. She next became a teacher at the government-sponsored Carlisle Indian Industrial School in 1897. Zitkala-Ša struggled with the school's harsh assimilationist policies and was forced out after two years. She then studied violin at the New England Conservatory of Music for two years.

Writing and Activism

In 1900 Zitkala-Ša began publishing short stories under her assumed name. These stories were semiautobiographical and dealt with her feelings of cultural conflict. They would eventually make up the first part of *American Indian Stories*. Shortly afterward, in 1901, she published her collection of Dakota folklore, *Old Indian Legends*. In 1902 Zitkala-Ša and her new husband, Raymond Bonnin, moved to a reservation in Utah, where she began working for the Society of American Indians. As a correspondent and the eventual secretary of the organization, Zitkala-Ša wrote many speeches, essays, and articles. In 1926 she founded the National Council of American Indians as a vehicle to support and promote Native Americans' rights.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Death and Legacy

Zitkala-Ša's work is a critical part of the canon of Native American writers, informing the works of many who succeeded her. Her writing reveals the struggles of Native Americans throughout the late 19th century and the first half of the 20th, a critical period in Native American history when much of the indigenous culture was systematically eradicated. Therefore, her writings are crucial in understanding the Native American experience of the time. She continued writing and advocating for indigenous Americans until her death on January 26, 1938.

Characters

Narrator

The narrator, or Zitkala-Ša in these stories, is a young Dakota girl, a happy, free spirit who is at one with nature. She and adores her mother and her way of life, but she can't help being attracted by the missionaries' stories and asks to go away to school with them. Her older brother has gone away to school in the East, and she hopes to go as well. Enthusiastic and curious at first, the narrator ends up deeply disappointed to discover the adults at the boarding school expect her to leave her whole culture behind and adopt theirs.

Iktomi

Greedy, selfish Iktomi is a classic trickster figure. In the story "Iktomi and the Ducks" he is described as a "spider fairy" who "dresses like a real Dakota brave." Although he is a trickster, his tricks rarely work out and almost always backfire on him. His lack of success may even seem pitiful, but he never learns from his mistakes and never changes his ways. Completely self-centered, Iktomi has no friends because he is always conning others and thus cannot be trusted.

Bureau of Indian Affairs

The Bureau of Indian Affairs, or BIA, is an organization Zitkala-Ša describes as "tyrannical." Though she worked for the BIA briefly, Zitkala-Ša is vehemently opposed to the institution because of its inefficiency and blatant hostility to Native Americans, and she argues for its dissolution. According to Zitkala-Ša, the Bureau is part of the bureaucracy that cripples indigenous communities and keeps them silenced.

Narrator's mother

Zitkala-Ša's mother has raised her daughter to be a free spirit and to value her culture. When her other daughter died on the Trail of Tears, her mother came to hate white men because of their complicity in her death. She also holds them responsible for her brother's death. The mother straddles two worlds, for she gave her children English names and sent her son, 10 years older than Zitkala-Ša, to an Eastern boarding school. She bitterly resents the loss of her way of life but knows her children must learn to live in the future.

The avenger

When the badger is desperate after being turned out of his house, he performs a ritual that results in the appearance of the avenger, a spirit in the form of an Indian brave. Carrying a magic arrow, he travels far and wide, righting wrongs and helping those in need. When characters see him, they recognize him immediately and are frightened by his power. Although he has shown he can be tricked, he wins in the end.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Full Character List

Character	Description
Narrator	The narrator of the stories "Impressions of an Indian Childhood," "The School Days of an Indian Girl," "An Indian Teacher Among Indians," "The Great Spirit," and "A Dream of Her Grandfather" is a partially fictionalized version of Zitkala-Ša herself. These stories have all been called *autobiographical* or *semiautobiographical*.
Iktomi	Iktomi is a trickster character who is always thwarted from getting what he wants. He appears in "Iktomi and the Ducks," "Iktomi's Blanket," "Iktomi and the Muskrat," "Iktomi and the Coyote," "Iktomi and the Fawn," "The Tree-Bound," "Shooting of the Red Eagle," and "Iktomi and the Turtle."
Bureau of Indian Affairs	The Bureau of Indian Affairs, while not a character per se, is a perpetual antagonist and one of the central entities in Zitkala-Ša's work. Founded in 1824 by then-Secretary of War John C. Calhoun (1782–1850), it is still in existence.
Narrator's mother	The narrator's, or Zitkala-Ša's, mother appears in the stories "Impressions of an Indian Childhood" and "An Indian Teacher Among Indians" and is mentioned elsewhere. She is a strong woman who cries rarely and hates white people.
The avenger	Born from a clot of buffalo blood, the avenger is a spirit in human form who helps characters who have been wronged. He appears in the story cycle "The Badger and the Bear," "The Tree-Bound," and "Shooting of the Red Eagle."
The badger	The badger of "The Badger and the Bear" is an honest, hardworking creature. When his home and all his possessions are stolen, the avenger appears to help him and his family.
The bear	The bear in "The Badger and the Bear" is a lazy, gluttonous creature who abuses the badger family's hospitality. He steals their dwelling and food rather than find his own.
Blue-Star Woman	An elderly Sioux, Blue-Star Woman is an orphan and cannot find proof of parentage to claim membership to the tribe. She is one of the protagonists of "The Widespread Enigma Concerning Blue-Star Woman."
Chief High Flier	Chief High Flier is a Sioux chief who tries to live with dignity and honesty but is unjustly imprisoned by the Indian police. He is the second protagonist in the story "The Widespread Enigma Concerning Blue-Star Woman."
Chipeta	Chipeta, whom Zitkala-Ša visits in "Chipeta, Widow of Chief Ouray with a Word About a Deal in Blankets," is the widow of a celebrated chief who saved his people and white settlers multiple times. She is herself a respected, but perhaps naive, elder.
Dawée	Dawée is the narrator's brother in "Impressions of an Indian Childhood," "The School Days of an Indian Girl," and "An Indian Teacher Among Indians." The fictionalized version of Zitkala-Ša's brother David, he is 10 years older and attended an Indian boarding school.
Iya	Iya, also known as "the eater," is a monsterlike being who eats whole camps of people. He appears in the legends "Iya, the Camp-Eater" and "The Warlike Seven."
Judéwin	In Zitkala-Ša's stories "Impressions of an Indian Childhood" and "The School Days of an Indian Girl," Judéwin is one of the narrator's friends from home. She knows some words of English and innocently helps the other girls, if not always to their benefit.
Muskrat	The muskrat in "Iktomi and the Muskrat" outsmarts Iktomi and wins his food back from him.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Chief Powhatan	Chief Powhatan (1545–1618) was a Native American leader at the time the Jamestown Colony was founded (1607). He appears in "The Coronation of Chief Powhatan Retold."
Sioux grandmother	The Sioux grandmother of "A Sioux Woman's Love for Her Grandchild" is devoted to her little granddaughter. When the rest of her tribe flees an oncoming army, she bravely refuses to leave without the child.
The soft-hearted Sioux	The soft-hearted Sioux of the story "The Soft-Hearted Sioux" is a young indigenous man who converts to Christianity but struggles to get food for his family because he has lost the ways of his culture.
Thowin	Thowin is the one of the narrator's friends from the reservation who attend school with her in "The School Days of an Indian Girl."
Tusee	In "A Warrior's Daughter" Tusee is the daughter of a respected warrior. A warrior herself, she shows courage and intelligence when she rescues her lover.
Winona	Winona is the protagonist's lover in "A Ballad." She lends her lover her beloved horse.

Plot Summary

Old Indian Legends

Many legends in this collection focus on the Dakota trickster figure of Iktomi and the trouble into which he gets himself and others. Iktomi tricks ducks into being eaten and then loses them to a pack of wolves. He prays for food but then takes back his offering and loses the food in "Iktomi's Blanket." In "Iktomi and the Muskrat" Iktomi tries to trick a muskrat into a race to win the muskrat's food. The muskrat then tricks Iktomi and keeps his feast. A similar contest and outcome take place in "Iktomi and the Turtle." In the story cycle "The Badger and the Bear," "The Tree-Bound," and "Shooting of the Red Eagle" an "avenger" helps various characters in need. In the first story, the badger calls the avenger forth from a clot of buffalo blood, and the avenger helps the badger get his home back from a greedy bear. In the following two stories the avenger is first tricked by Iktomi, but upon escaping he helps rid a village of a menacing red eagle. In "The Toad and the Boy" an Indian baby is stolen and raised by a toad but eventually returns to his human parents. "Iya, the Camp-Eater" tells of a monster who eats whole camps. The rabbit in "Manštin, the Rabbit" learns the value of appreciating what he has. "The Warlike Seven" warns readers not to underestimate someone who may seem small and harmless.

American Indian Stories

The first four stories of *American Indian Stories* recount the author's childhood experiences, first growing up with her mother and later finding her way in the white world. Zitkala-Ša paints a picture of an ideal childhood with her mother and loves listening to the elders tell legends. When she is eight, she begs her mother to let her go with missionaries to attend boarding school but is miserable when she arrives. After boarding school, she describes her struggle teaching at another Indian boarding school, where she begins to sink into a depression and lose faith. In the story "The Great Spirit" she describes regained faith in her culture and in the Great Spirit (universal spiritual force).

The fifth story, "The Softhearted Sioux," tells of a young Sioux man who converts to Christianity. When his father is sick and dying, the young man, who has abandoned his Native culture, is unable to hunt and get food for his parents, so he eventually steals the food, kills his pursuer, and is hanged as punishment. In "The Trial Path" a grandmother tells her granddaughter the story of how she ended up married at different times to two best friends, one of whom killed the other from jealousy. In "A Warrior's Daughter" a woman saves her lover when he is captured during a battle. The narrator is given a vision of hope in the story "A Dream of Her Grandfather." The final two entries, the last one not a story, relate instances of injustice perpetrated against Native Americans by a bureaucraticgovernment system.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Selections from *American Indian Magazine*

The pieces in this section are collected from Zitkala-Ša's contributions to *American Indian Magazine*. The prose articles deal with issues pertinent to Native Americans at the time. She writes calling for Native Americans to be granted citizenship and for the Bureau of Indian Affairs to be dissolved. The Bureau of Indian Affairs is an agency under the U.S. Department of the Interior that serves as a liaison between Native populations and the U.S. government. The poem "The Red Man's America" is a reworking of the lyrics to the song "America" to highlight issues facing indigenous Americans. The other poem, "A Sioux Woman's Love for Her Grandchild," tells the story of a brave grandmother sacrificing herself for her grandchild. In the article "Indian Gifts to Civilized Man" Zitkala-Ša relates the foods cultivated by American Indians that help the United States during wartime. Many of these articles were written during World War I (1914–18) and detail the extensive contributions by Native Americans to the war effort, despite experiencing ongoing injustice.

Poetry, Pamphlets, Essays, and Speeches

The entries are arranged chronologically, beginning with Zitkala-Ša's 1896 speech "Side by Side," which won the Earlham College oratorical competition. The speech gives a general history of Native Americans before colonial powers came to America. It also condemns colonizers' treatment of indigenous people and defends indigenous actions of revenge and violence toward white settlers. The poem, "A Ballad," tells the story of a young woman whose lover is betrayed in battle but manages to survive. It is followed by another poem, "Iris of Life," a celebratory piece about the human spirit. "A Protest Against the Abolition of the Indian Dance" is an essay defending the importance and spirit of Native American dance. In the essay that follows, Zitkala-Ša reveals her opposition to peyote use, urging its immediate restriction. Peyote is a species of hallucinogenic cactus. In the essays "Americanize the First American" and "Bureaucracy versus Democracy," Zitkala-Ša speaks out about the government-created bureaucracy that is repressing and destroying indigenous people. In "A Dakota Ode to Washington," a group of elders send a message to Washington, D.C. lauding U.S. president George Washington (1732–99). The final four essays focus on the traditions, trials, and betrayals of the indigenous California people during the gold rush (1848–52). During the California gold rush, the state experienced a rapid influx of people in search of fortune after gold was discovered at Sutter's Mill in Coloma. Zitkala-Ša points to the secret and forgotten treaties the government made and broke with the people of California. She insists the people should receive justice all these years later.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Chapter Summaries

Part 1, Preface–Iktomi and the Fawn

Summary

Preface

Zitkala-Ša introduces her collection of Dakota legends as important glimpses into the interconnectivity of all humans. She insists these legends reveal a "sincerity of belief" in indigenous cultures that is in fact present in all cultures. Part of her purpose in relating these stories in English, she explains, is to make them accessible to the "blue-eyed little patriot." In other words, she hopes to give white colonizers of the Americas a deeper understanding of the country's original peoples.

Iktomi and the Ducks

Iktomi is a trickster fairy who dresses "like a real Dakota brave." Because he is conceited and loves playing tricks, he is lonely and has no friends. In this story Iktomi is hungry and tricks a group of ducks into dancing with their eyes closed, telling them that whoever opens their eyes will be cursed with red eyes. While the ducks dance, Iktomi snatches them one by one and wrings their necks. Finally, one of the ducks opens its eyes and raises the alarm. The ducks fly away, but their eyes turn red.

Iktomi takes his brace of ducks back home and begins to cook them. While they are cooking, Iktomi climbs a nearby tree to find the source of some annoying creaking sounds. He becomes caught in the tree, and while he struggles to escape, a pack of wolves come along and eat all of his ducks.

Iktomi's Blanket

Hungry because the wolves ate his ducks, Iktomi prays to the stone grandfather god, Inyan, for food. As an offering he leaves his only blanket. On the way back to his house, Iktomi stumbles across a newly killed deer and realizes his prayers are answered. He takes it home and starts to cook it over a fire. It is evening now, and he is cold without his blanket. Iktomi selfishly returns to the stone god and takes the blanket back. When he returns to his fire, the venison has disappeared, and Iktomi laments not having eaten it before he went back for the blanket.

Iktomi and the Muskrat

Iktomi sits eating soup by the edge of a lake. A muskrat appears and waits for Iktomi to follow the "custom of the plains people" and offer him some soup. Instead, Iktomi offers to race the muskrat for the whole pot of soup. He is overconfident and forgets that muskrats can move quickly underwater. When he returns to his soup, he finds the pot empty and the muskrat in the tree above. The muskrat laughs at Iktomi and drops a bone down his throat. It gets stuck and nearly chokes Iktomi, as the muskrat reminds him to follow Dakota ways and share his food.

Iktomi and the Coyote

Iktomi comes across a sleeping coyote lying in the grass and mistakes it for dead. On his shoulders Iktomi carries the coyote—now awake and enjoying the ride—back to his dwelling and makes a fire to cook it. He dances around and flings the coyote onto the flames. The coyote, now wide awake, leaps out of the coals and frightens Iktomi, who screams. Laughing, and warning Iktomi not to "take too much for granted," the coyote runs off into the plains.

Iktomi and the Fawn

Later Iktomi comes across a peacock, an arrow, and then a fawn. When he expresses a desire to be like the peacock, the peacock makes him into a peacock, with one restriction. Iktomi doesn't accept the restriction—he is unable to fly—and is turned back into himself. Then he meets an arrow and wants to be an arrow. His wish is granted, with one restriction. Iktomi doesn't accept the restriction—he must fly only in a straight line—and is turned back into his buckskin-clad self. Next, when he admires a fawn's spots, the fawn tricks Iktomi into burying himself with a hot coal under grass so he can have spots like

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

the fawn. The deer go off laughing, as the grass goes up in smoke.

Analysis

Zitkala-Ša's preface to her collection of Dakota stories reveals her desire to attain respect among white culture for her indigenous Dakota culture. She makes several slightly barbed remarks about the history of the United States and the importance of white colonists accepting that they inherit that history. For instance, Zitkala-Ša employs verbal irony (in which what is said is the opposite of what is meant) in the phrase "when they are grown tall like the wise grown-ups." She does not view many of the so-called adults who have colonized the Americas, killing and repressing indigenous people, as being really "wise." But there is also a hopefulness in this statement that the children of colonizers will have more wisdom than their parents. Zitkala-Ša comments that "America in the last few centuries has acquired a second tongue"—referring to the English language. This, she explains, is why she has chosen to translate a selection of her people's tales into English. From her preface readers can discern Zitkala-Ša is disillusioned with colonization but still hopes to build a bridge between white culture and her own. Despite the history of repression, assimilation, and violence toward indigenous peoples, Zitkala-Ša expresses the hope that an understanding can be reached, adding that when white children grow "tall like the wise grown-ups may they not lack interest in a further study of Indian folklore."

The stories of Iktomi are classic trickster tales. The trickster archetype is found in folklore across most cultures, from Loki in Norse mythology, to the Caribbean Anansi, to the French Reynard the fox and his European counterparts. Like many of these figures, Iktomi sometimes changes shape and can appear in different forms. He has moments of wisdom and wit, such as contriving a plan to capture ducks for a feast or giving his blanket to the stone figure as an offering. However, these moments are always quickly countered by a trickster's particular brand of foolishness. Iktomi always manages to spoil his own plans with his self-centered, calculating nature. When he takes the blanket back from the grandfather god Inyan, he doesn't regret taking the blanket and going back on something he has, in a sense, promised, but he regrets being so foolish as to take the blanket before eating his feast. This action exemplifies Iktomi's lack of moral compass. His decisions are based not on compassion, courtesy, or tradition but on self-preservation, self-satisfaction, and greed. And the trickster is invariably tricked. For Zitkala-Ša, Iktomi is also likely a symbol of the white colonizers, who "play tricks" on the Native Americans. The so-called tricks of the colonizers are the reneged promises and acts of violence and genocide perpetrated against indigenous peoples.

The stories in this collection can be categorized as fables. Fables are stories about animal characters or other types of nonhumans who are anthropomorphized, or given human qualities such as the ability to speak. Fables always include a moral or lesson, as does each Iktomi story. Although Iktomi often does not heed or understand that lesson, the audience is certainly meant to. Some of the lessons are about particular qualities, such as the importance and weight of sacrifice in "Iktomi and the Blanket." Other stories, like "Iktomi and the Muskrat," teach manners that are culturally important. The lesson in "Iktomi and the Fawn" is more subtle, however. Iktomi's actions and their consequences teach about the importance of finding satisfaction in what one has and not coveting qualities or things belonging to others. The story also demonstrates the importance of not making decisions or promises lightly. By thoughtlessly promising things he doesn't understand, Iktomi loses one shape after another and is finally the victim of a prank much like one he himself might play.

Part 1, The Badger and the Bear–Shooting of the Red Eagle

Summary

The Badger and the Bear

A badger family is initially blessed with a comfortable dwelling, arrows to hunt for food, and plenty of meat drying for the winter. One day the father badger stays home making arrows instead of hunting, and a hungry, sickly bear comes to visit. The family treat him hospitably and feed him meat. He returns and is treated well day after day until he is healthy and strong.

At this point the bear betrays the family's kindness and throws

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

them out of their house. The badger family goes hungry while the bear family enjoy their stolen dwelling and meat. The father badger builds a little hut for his family, but he cannot hunt without his arrows, which are in the house the bears now occupy. When the father badger begs the bear for some food, the bear refuses him and throws him out of the house. Feeling sorry for the badger family, the youngest bear steals some meat for them.

Soon after, the father badger takes some buffalo blood from one of the bear's kills and uses it in a ceremony to ask the Great Spirit to bless his family. A human brave, carrying a magic arrow, grows from the buffalo blood. Known as an avenger, he goes with the father badger to ask the bear for meat. The bear realizes this Dakota brave is the avenger. In terror the bears all flee to the forest as the happy badgers return home.

The Tree-Bound

"The Tree-Bound" continues the tale of the avenger. After helping the badger family, the avenger travels to a small village being terrorized by a red eagle. The village chieftain offers marriage to one of his two daughters as a reward to any warrior who can kill the eagle. All the warriors try to shoot the bird, but none is successful. Rumor of a young man with a magic arrow reaches the village, and the chieftain, believing the man to be the avenger—born of buffalo blood, who saved the badgers—sends messengers to bring him to the village in the hope he can kill the red eagle with his magic arrow.

Overhearing the men tell the chieftain the avenger is coming, Iktomi decides he wants the magic arrow so he can marry one of the chieftain's daughters. Iktomi then tricks the avenger into killing a bird for food and climbing a tree to get it. While the avenger is in the tree, Iktomi further tricks him into tossing down his clothing to protect it from being torn, and tossing down the magic arrow, which Iktomi offers to clean. When he has these items, Iktomi causes the tree to grow around the avenger, binding him to it. Iktomi takes the avenger's buckskins and arrow and leaves him stuck. The avenger is rescued later by a woman who cuts him loose, and he heads for the troubled village to tell the chieftain what has happened.

Shooting of the Red Eagle

In the final story of the cycle, Iktomi sits on a hilltop and waits for the warriors of the village to notice him. The warriors think he is the avenger and carry him back to the chieftain's house with great ceremony. The chieftain and his wife feed Iktomi and give him a place to sleep. The next day Iktomi goes out at dawn before all the people of the village and tries to shoot the red eagle, but all of his arrows miss. At this point the woman who helped free the avenger arrives in the village and tells the story of Iktomi's trickery. The villagers throw Iktomi out of the village, and the real avenger arrives. He kills the red eagle immediately and wins one of the chieftain's daughters as a wife.

Analysis

This cycle of three stories follows a different pattern from the previous stories about the trickster Iktomi. While Iktomi's stories focus primarily on a moral lesson, this story cycle focuses on a central figure called the "avenger" and his legendary arrow. Although animal characters are present, the stories are not fables. In each story the righteous characters and the hero emerge victorious, but otherwise they convey no particular lesson. They are classic stories of goodness, honesty, and bravery triumphing over laziness and deceit, much like fairy tales.

The badger family are good, honest, and hardworking and treat their guest with correct courtesy, even though it means dipping into their own food stores. The bear family, however, are lazy, discourteous, and, finally, cruel. They get their way by stealing the home and possessions of the honest badgers. This situation is out of balance, and because the badger father performs the correct ritual and prays to the Great Spirit, he is rewarded by the birth of the avenger. The avenger rights the imbalance, returning the honest badgers to their home and chasing off the deceitful bears. The youngest bear cub, who gives the badgers some meat and doesn't feel right about laughing at them, is one of the story's strange loose ends. He performs a good deed out of a sense of compassion yet sees no reward from it. His only reward is knowing he did right. The badger family is rewarded for living correctly and honestly, but the bear cub is presumably turned out with his family and forced to go hungry again. This makes the moral aspect of the story a little hazy. If the message is that each character gets

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

their just deserts, readers might wonder why the bear cub does not.

Another curious part of this cycle involves the birds in the tale. There is a "yellow-breasted birdie" who sings "friend, you're a Dakota!" at the avenger. Yet later, because of Iktomi's trickery, the avenger shoots and kills the bird with his magic arrow. The avenger is unpunished for the bird's death and is ultimately unaware of its friendship. The bird displays loyalty and goodwill toward the avenger but is never mentioned again after its death. In addition, there is no explanation of why the bird's actions cause problems. It flies over the village and frightens the villagers but never does anything more antagonistic. It also may seem odd that the antagonist is an eagle, the sacred symbol of honesty and bravery. Often in stories rooted deeply in culture and place, elements may be difficult to understand without having a grounding in that context. The red eagle likely falls into this category.

Iktomi reappears in this story cycle to stir up trouble, though he is neither the main character nor the antagonist. Instead he appears to thwart the hero from dealing with the true antagonist, the red eagle. Situations like this one are often the case with traditional trickster figures, whose roles may be to play on the weaknesses of others to get them into trouble or inflame a conflict already present.

Part 1, Iktomi and the Turtle–The Toad and the Boy

Summary

Iktomi and the Turtle

Patkaša, the huntsman turtle, fails to kill any deer while hunting. Feeling sorry for him, kind spirits lead him to a deer killed by another hunter. Iktomi appears and proposes a contest for the deer. The contest is, of course, not to Patkaša's advantage, so he loses. Asking Patkaša to guard the deer, Iktomi goes to get his children to feast on the deer, but when he returns, both Patkaša and the deer have disappeared. Iktomi and his children see Patkaša beneath the surface of a stream, and Iktomi dives in to get the venison from Patkaša's campfire. However, Patkaša is actually in a tree and has fooled Iktomi with his reflection. Iktomi drowns and his children cry "for their water-dead father."

Dance in a Buffalo Skull

A party of mice dance under the stars in a buffalo skull. The mice dance and drum and feast, oblivious to a pair of fiery eyes moving toward them across the plain. The darkness hides the body of the beast with the eyes. The beast approaches the buffalo skull and peers through the eye sockets. Frightened, the mice momentarily think the buffalo spirit has returned. Then they realize the eyes belong to a cat, and the mice flee across the prairie.

The Toad and the Boy

Expecting her husband to return shortly, a young mother leaves her baby boy in her tepee while she goes to cut willow branches for the fire. When she returns, the baby has disappeared. The mother and father call and hunt everywhere for him. Ten years pass, and they find no trace of the boy, and his mother still weeps. One day, a wild boy hears the woman crying and is moved by her tears. When he returns to his toad mother and asks about the woman, the toad mother attempts to show her human son she, too, can move him with her tears. "Not knowing that the syllables of a Dakota's cry are the names of loved ones gone," the toad names valuable items as she sobs. The boy is unmoved, and the toad mother realizes she must return him to his human parents. However, she is reluctant to part with him and sends one of her toad children to accompany him at all times. When a hunter sees the boy, he realizes he is the lost child, and the family is reunited.

Analysis

Each of these three stories—"Iktomi and the Turtle," "Dance in a Buffalo Skull," and "The Toad and the Boy"—illustrate different types of legends. The story of "Iktomi and the Turtle" is similar to other stories in which Iktomi appears as a main character that attempts to trick an honest being out of their food and ends up hurting himself instead. This pattern is typical of the trickster archetype. The character of Wile E. Coyote, for example, embodies one of the most significant instances of this in modern American popular culture. Each attempt to trick

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

the roadrunner ultimately backfires. In this way Iktomi, too, is always the victim of his own trickery. Although generally goodhearted, the turtle also has a sense of self-preservation that allows him to turn Iktomi's trickery back on him.

The other two stories do not follow a form with a lesson or moral. The story of the mice in the buffalo skull is primarily a descriptive piece. With no clear plot or protagonist, it is more of a glimpse into the activities of creatures who inhabit the plains at night. The buffalo is a sacred animal to all plains peoples, as illustrated by the mice who dance and celebrate in its skull. The buffalo was an important food source and thus appears frequently in stories and legends of plains peoples. The mice in this story eat the meat of the buffalo and dance in a celebration, mirroring the traditions of the humans living on the plains.

In "The Toad and the Boy" the classic plot line of the feral child raised by animals appears across many cultures. Many of those stories deal with lost or abandoned children, although in this story it is not revealed how the boy disappears. It is possible to assume the toad mother takes him while his real mother is collecting branches. At the core of this story, however, is the idea that a human child needs its human family, and no other creature can replace a human mother. It is noteworthy that the woman's sobbing mentions the names of departed loved ones, whereas the toad's false sobbing mentions valuable items. The difference reveals the depth of feeling and attachment between the two mothers. For the woman, the boy is part of herself and her life; for the toad he is a valuable commodity. This bond explains why the boy is saddened by the tears of his birth mother but feels nothing when the toad attempts to cry. The toad mother recognizes this as well and thus knows the boy must return to his human mother.

Part 1, Iya, the Camp-Eater–The Warlike Seven

Summary

Iya, the Camp-Eater

A group of hunters stumble across a crying baby in the woods. They take him back to the village, where the chieftain decides the baby will become his daughter's adopted son. The village has a huge celebration in honor of the chieftain's daughter and the baby that evening. One man fears the baby is an evil spirit in disguise, but the chief brushes aside his concerns. That night, the daughter is awake with the baby while the rest of the village sleeps. Hearing odd voices that seem like many voices getting increasingly louder, she consults her father. They realize the sounds are coming from the sleeping child's open mouth and are from a large village inside the baby. As the man feared earlier, the baby is an evil spirit: "Iya" who eats camps. Because Iya is powerful only at night, the whole village steals away quietly, leaving the sleeping baby. When he awakens, he becomes enraged at being tricked and reveals his true form. He chases the village, but by daylight he is less dangerous, and the warriors manage to kill him. A huge camp springs out of him, and its inhabitants thank the villagers for saving them.

Manŝtin, the Rabbit

Manŝtin, a brave and compassionate rabbit, heads northward to hunt. Along the way he encounters a monster named Double-Face torturing a human baby. Manŝtin shoots Double-Face and returns the child to his parents. That night Manŝtin turns the baby into a full-grown man, and they swear friendship to one another.

After leaving the couple and the newly grown man, Manŝtin comes to a stream and a blind man's hut. The blind man has a system of ropes that lead him to the stream for water and the forest for firewood, and he has bags that magically refill themselves with dried meat. Manŝtin exclaims he would swap his eyes for the blind man's life, and the blind man agrees to the exchange. However, Manŝtin is incautious and manages to lose the ropes when trying to go to the stream and the forest. He first falls into the stream and then gets lost in the woods. When Manŝtin cries out for help, the blind man appears with Manŝtin's friend from the previous evening. The old man returns Manŝtin's eyes, and Manŝtin learns his lesson.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

The Warlike Seven

Seven beings go out to make war. They are Ashes, Fire, Bladder (refers to bladder of a large animal such as a bison, often used to make bags or pouches), Grasshopper, Dragonfly, Fish, and Turtle. Along the way, each encounters an obstacle that kills them, until only the Fish and the Turtle remain. When the Fish and the Turtle come to a village and announce they are there to make war, the people laugh and decide to cook the animals. The villagers hold the Fish over the pot of boiling water, but the Fish blows the water onto the villagers and blinds them. Hoping to drown the Fish and the Turtle, the villagers throw the pair into the lake, but both creatures live happily in the water. Finally, the people call Iya, the Eater, to come and drink up the lake. The Fish and the Turtle burrow into the mud, however, and are not eaten. Iktomi is present and gets swallowed with the lake water. When he cuts his way out of the Eater's stomach, the lake rushes out and drowns the village. Thus, the Fish and the Turtle win their war.

Analysis

The final three stories of Zitkala-Ša's *Old Indian Legends* represent a mix of story types. "Iya, the Camp-Eater" introduces the mythological character of "The Camp-Eater," or as he is later known "The Eater." Although the story is perhaps a warning against bringing strange beings into the village without knowing anything about them, more importantly, it introduces an important figure in the folklore of the Dakota people. Iya is destroyed in this story, but like the story in which Iktomi drowns, his destruction doesn't stop him from appearing in other stories. These separate legends do not seem to follow a timeline but instead tell self-contained tales about important figures in Dakota folklore.

The happy ending of this tale goes beyond the village being saved and Iya slain. The killing of Iya frees another entire village that was eaten. This event is later mirrored in "The Warlike Seven," when Iya swallows a whole lake. In both stories Iya consumes but does not kill. He swallows Iktomi along with the lake, but Iktomi remains alive in Iya's stomach. This archetype of the monster that eats things whole, only to regurgitate or have them escape later, appears in other mythologies as well. The whale in the story of Jonah and the whale and the wolf in some versions of Little Red Riding Hood are two well-known examples of this archetype.

The moralizing fable returns in "Manštin, the Rabbit." Zitkala-Ša describes Manštin as possessing many good qualities, such as kindness and bravery. Although he is not like Iktomi, who is usually on the receiving end of a story's lesson, Manštin learns a gentle lesson when he swaps out his eyes for the supposed "easy" life of the old blind man. The lesson is "gentle" because no harm comes to Manštin when he finds himself lost in the woods. When he is in trouble, the old man and Manštin's friend come to save him. The moral of the story, though never explicitly stated, is to appreciate what one has. Manštin does not fully appreciate his eyes and trades them readily for a life of ease. That life is not his life; it belongs to the old man. By trying to live someone else's life, Manštin ends up lost and in trouble. Only by living his own life and recognizing the value of his senses and his health will Manštin fulfill his purpose.

The final story features a cast of characters of hazy significance. Perhaps there is a cultural context to why the seven characters are what they are. These characters likely have mythological meaning in the Dakota tradition, but the author does not explain it in this collection. The lesson in the ending of the story, as the Fish and the Turtle succeed in their quest to make war, is not to underestimate adversaries, no matter what they may look like.

Part 2, Impressions of an Indian Childhood

Summary

The narrator recalls her life as a young child being raised in a Dakota village on the plains by her mother, who is both sad and bitter about the forced relocation of their people. She blames the white man for the death of her brother and older daughter, who were sick during the relocation and died shortly after. Though her mother attempts to keep her sadness to herself, the narrator remembers her crying sometimes.

The mother would often invite the village elders to come share dinner and tell stories. The narrator, as a young child, would sit next to her and ask to hear the myths and legends. Zitkala-Ša also learned beadwork from her mother. She learned to design patterns—avoiding anything too complex because she had to finish what she started—choose color combinations, and stitch

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

the beads onto buckskin. Zitkala-Ša also reminisces about playing with her friends outside in the summer and running free after long hours of doing beadwork. The children would gather "sweet roots," exchanging beadwork as temporary "gifts," and impersonating their mothers.

In another memory, the narrator serves a grandfather bread and muddy water. Because she doesn't know how to make coffee, she pours river water over old coffee grounds in the coffee pot and sets it on ashes rather than a fire. The grandfather politely sips the water and eats the bread until the author's mother returns and realizes what has happened. Neither adult embarrasses the child by chastising her. Another day, on their way to a feast, Zitkala-Ša reaches out to pick some plums from a bush. Her mother stops her, explaining that the bush grows from the corpse of a dead warrior, who loved to play "a game of striped plum seeds" and therefore was buried with his set of seeds. Because of this burial, the bush is sacred and she should never eat its plums. Another memory details Zitkala-Ša's mother drying sweet corn, and a yellow-and-black-striped squirrel coming every morning to take some of the kernels.

The final memory explains how the narrator comes to attend a boarding school run by missionaries. Her older brother advises against it, and her mother, warning of white men's heartlessness and treachery, is reluctant to let her go. Despite her mother's warnings, she is enticed by the missionaries' stories, particularly about orchards full of apples. Recognizing the importance of an education, her mother lets her go, having been encouraged by her older sister, Zitkala-Ša's beloved aunt.

Analysis

In this first installment of Zitkala-Ša's semiautobiographical *American Indian Stories*, the author recounts incidents she remembers when she was seven and eight. These seem to be the last years she lived with her mother in their village. A sense of strong nostalgia permeates this series of memories, probably because they mark the last ones Zitkala-Ša has of living with her family in a traditional way. At age eight, she goes off to boarding school, not understanding what she is giving up or what kind of life she is entering. All her memories in this series revolve around her mother and their relationship. Zitkala-Ša seems to hold her mother in the highest esteem, and she recounts situations in which her mother treated her with dignity and respect. She portrays her mother as someone highly respected by their community.

Zitkala-Ša's memories reveal the source of the collected legends that form the first part of this collection. Her love of sitting with the elders in her mother's home while they told the stories of Iktomi and other creatures is evident in her recollections. It is presumably this love, as well as a desire to share these legends with people outside her community, that motivates Zitkala-Ša to commit the stories to paper. Many of the lessons Zitkala-Ša's collected legends teach are reflected in her own upbringing. The importance of courtesy toward guests, for example, appears frequently in the legends as well as in Zitkala-Ša's attempt to serve coffee to an elder. She learns to listen carefully and not impose herself into a place or situation before taking stock of the atmosphere. In the memory of the plum bush, Zitkala-Ša learns to respect sacred places and beings and does not pick the plums even though she wants them. The lessons and customs illustrated in these memories are real-life instances of the moral teachings in Zitkala-Ša's beloved legends.

Threaded throughout Zitkala-Ša's early memories is the lurking danger of the "paleface." Even as a child she notices her mother's hatred for the white man, though she clearly doesn't understand its depth. A young Zitkala-Ša claims to hates the white man because her mother does and because she associates them with her mother's crying. However, a year later she begs her mother to go with the white missionaries to school. At this point, Zitkala-Ša has no real understanding of the relationship between her people and the white men. Outside her mother's blame and bitterness, she has no knowledge of what damage they have done to her community. Zitkala-Ša is a young eight-year-old child who dreams of eating rare, tasty apples and attending school with her friends. She wants to see new places and embark on adventures. But not until she is riding away from her village do the implications of her choice begin to dawn on her.

Part 2, The School Days of an Indian Girl

Summary

Zitkala-Ša goes East via train to boarding school with seven

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

other children from her community. The trip is difficult, and she quickly grows to resent the stares of the other passengers. When she arrives at the school, everything is unfamiliar, and she finds herself crying from exhaustion and confusion. On her first day, when Zitkala-Ša learns they plan to cut her hair off, she hides in an attempt at rebellion. In the traditions of her people, short hair is a sign of mourning or cowardice. She is caught, however, and her long hair is chopped off.

The author relates other unpleasant incidents at school. That winter Zitkala-Ša is playing with her friends Judéwin and Thowin in the snow, falling in a drift and leaving impressions of their bodies. A teacher at the school catches them and scolds them. The word Judéwin, who knows some English, has taught them is *no*, so Thowin gets a more severe scolding and a whipping when asked whether she will obey. Later, an angry Zitkala-Ša, punished for a minor infraction, mashes turnips too hard as an act of rebellion and mashes the bottom of the glass jar right out. No turnips are served at dinner, pleasing Zitkala-Ša, who dislikes them. One day after a teacher tells Zitkala-Ša about the devil, she has a terrifying dream about him that night. The next day she uses a pencil to scratch the eyes out of the illustration of the devil in a book of Bible stories. Zitkala-Ša also reminisces about the harshness of the students' routine and the loss of a friend to illness.

Later, Zitkala-Ša returns home for summers between school terms. She feels she no longer fits into her old world with her mother or into the new world of school. Desperate for some freedom, she rides her brother's horse and chases a coyote. That night she is not allowed to attend a party, and the rage and sadness bubble up in her. Zitkala-Ša's mother goes outside and keens a lament for her daughter's sadness. After Zitkala-Ša finally graduates from school, she and her mother have a falling out over Zitkala-Ša's decision to stay in the East and attend college. Zitkala-Ša does well in oration and wins several speaking contests. The students at her school are supportive and excited for her, but when she attends a contest against other universities, she finds herself the target of racial slurs.

Analysis

The child Zitkala-Ša does not experience a lightning-bolt realization of the kind of life she has entered. Instead, her understanding comes gradually. As she learns the routine of the school, she finds herself punished for rules she doesn't understand and forced to do things contrary to her beliefs and culture. These moments, and a growing sense of confinement, build to become the basis of her new life. Each time Zitkala-Ša describes herself and her friends as having fun, she illustrates how the school punishes them for it. When they go outside to play in the snow, they are playing as they used to on the plains. Shortly afterward they are dragged into an authority figure's office and punished for this small act of freedom. While at school, Zitkala-Ša never describes an act of enjoyment or autonomy that goes unpunished. The picture she creates of her life in the school is one of repression and white authority figures set on forcing children to forget their "Indianness." These childhood experiences mirror what she later experiences as an adult. Her descriptions of life in the world of white people also relate a life of repression, racism, and a struggle with cultural identity.

Zitkala-Ša's recounting of this time in her life begins with her experiences on the train, or "iron horse." She begins to suspect at this time that life in the East will not be the fairytale she and the others were promised. People stare at her and her friends in a way that makes her uncomfortable. She notes the adults did not correct the children's rude staring, but instead they too "looked closely at me, and attracted their children's further notice to my blanket." Zitkala-Ša implies that in her cultural upbringing, this kind of behavior from children would be unacceptable. Thus, she feels confused by the mothers' condoning and even copying their children's rudeness. Zitkala-Ša's confusion begins on the train and continues through the first few years of school. With no understanding of English and no concept of white social or cultural norms, Zitkala-Ša must fumble her way through fear and punishment to learn what is expected of her.

Zitkala-Ša's changing relationship with her mother mirrors the changes happening in her village and in herself. When she returns home, she is restless. That night, she watches the slightly older youths of the village go to a gathering. She describes their change from buckskin to "paleface" clothing, and weeps because she cannot go. She exists somewhere between the world into which she was born and the new world that is entering her people's culture. As she continues her education and her journey in the white man's world, Zitkala-Ša grows increasingly distant from her mother. Eventually a rift forms between them as a result of Zitkala-Ša's choice to stay in the East and go to college. Zitkala-Ša's mother cannot understand the changes her daughter has undergone, and Zitkala-Ša cannot go back to being the person she was before

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

she left home.

Part 2, An Indian Teacher Among Indians

Summary

When illness forces Zitkala-Ša to leave college, she goes to work for an "Indian School" farther East, hoping to make a difference for other indigenous children. She arrives at the school and is shown to her room. Before she has time to get settled, her employer knocks on the door, wishing to meet her. Zitkala-Ša know she looks frail and ill and suspects her employer is disappointed by what he sees.

After she has been teaching at the school for a while, the superintendent sends her back out West to collect more pupils. On the way she stops to visit with her mother. Although she still uses her tepee, she is now living in a rough log cabin that is not completely weatherproof. She confesses to her daughter that Dawée has lost his job to a white man and that they have no money. She shows her daughter the settlement of poor white men in the bluffs and puts a curse on them, expressing her anger and hatred of white people and pointing "her outstretched fingers toward the settler's lodge, as if an invisible power passed from them to the evil at which she aimed."

When she returns to the school, Zitkala-Ša also expresses a growing resentment toward the white man. She has little use for some of the white staff at the school—an opium user, an alcoholic doctor, for example. She is angered by dishonest representation of students' accomplishments, and even more angered that she can't do anything about any of the indignities her people suffer. Thinking of her mother, her brother, and what she had to do to become who she is, she completely loses faith in the system and quits her job.

Analysis

At this point in her life, Zitkala-Ša begins to feel disillusioned with her goal to help indigenous people. Her ill health reflects her inner state as she becomes increasingly depressed. Initially she avoids telling her mother she is ill because she realizes her mother would reflect on a painful truth. Zitkala-Ša understands she has sacrificed her "freedom and health" for "the white man's papers" and has gained little from this sacrifice. Zitkala-Ša's mother sees the situation of her people with remarkably clear eyes. While Zitkala-Ša has been away, her mother studied the Bible enough to point out the hypocrisy of the white Christians' actions. She sees the injustice in how white people follow a creed that says "thou shalt not kill" but make an exception for Indians. But despite Zitkala-Ša's mother's anger and hatred, she has not given into despair as her daughter has. It is possible Zitkala-Ša's mother still holds out hope. However, Zitkala-Ša, who sees some of the worst of the white treatment of indigenous children in the boarding schools, has a despairing view of what will happen to her people.

Zitkala-Ša's experience living and working in white society strips her of her optimism and vigor. She is depressed with the realization that the system is not made to benefit the Native person at all but instead to give jobs to incompetent white people. Her despair takes her to a place where she no longer believes in the Great Spirit and can find no comfort in her mother or her old home. Along with her childhood, she loses her connection with nature and the freedom and wisdom that connection gave her. Contained in this loss is also the loss of her mother, because Zitkala-Ša's "lack of any" way of life is incompatible with her "mother's simple view of life." As a result of this growing despair, Zitkala-Ša sets aside her hope for a better life and for justice. With low expectations, she surmises she will not feel disappointed or crushed. She has cut herself off from her childhood, her family, her culture, and a large part of herself.

Part 2, The Great Spirit

Summary

Zitkala-Ša has made her peace with the Great Spirit. She describes wandering in the hills or alongside the Missouri River, enjoying the wildflowers and remembering legends from her childhood. She goes to her mother's cabin, where her elderly mother lives with a shaggy black dog. After her time in nature she expresses a more peaceful attitude toward the white man and his existence alongside indigenous people. A "native preacher" comes to her mother's house and tries to convince Zitkala-Ša to attend church service. She does not

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

respond except to feed him lunch and then send him on his way. She prefers her "excursions into the natural gardens" to the Christian dogma.

Analysis

Zitkala-Ša seems to have two primary intentions in this story. The first is to communicate the peace she has found back home amid nature. The second is to describe the way Christianity has infiltrated the lives and beliefs of her people. The first half of the story describes her nearly mystical experience with nature. Zitkala-Ša has regained some of her childhood freedom and connection with nature, but it is now more conscious. This reconnection has rekindled her spirit and improved her health, and she once again writes of faith in the Great Spirit. Her attitude toward white people also seems affected by this transformation. She now writes she understands "the racial lines, which once were bitterly real" have no purpose other "than marking out a living mosaic of human beings." No longer speaking of hatred or the broken system, she takes a philosophical and more positive approach to the conflict between peoples.

Zitkala-Ša also discusses the presence of Christianity in the village and in her mother's life. In the interim since last seeing her, Zitkala-Ša's mother has converted to Christianity, the result of thinking she experienced a miracle. Though Zitkala-Ša expresses no opinion about her mother's conversion, she herself remains unconverted. She seems to accept that God and the Great Spirit are one and the same but calls Christianity "a bigoted creed." It is likely the introduction of Christianity to the village has caused great changes in her culture, though she does not yet describe them.

Part 2, The Soft-Hearted Sioux

Summary

A 16-year-old Sioux is sitting by the fire in his tepee, his family asking him whether he has a woman in mind to marry. He insists he is too young, and his family give him advice on how to live: be active, and "do not dislike a long hunt."

Nine years later he returns from living among white people and hopes to bring Christianity to his village. His father is ill and dying. A friend of his father's cautions the young man not to throw the medicine man out of his father's house, though the young man is impatient, grief-stricken, and angry. When the medicine man visits another time, the young man tries to convert him to Christianity. When this does not work, he throws the medicine man out of the wigwam, despite his father's tears.

The young man tries to convert his people, telling "them of the soft heart of Christ," but, led by the medicine man, they call him a traitor and leave him and his family when they move camp. Prayer does not help them, and they are soon starving. Day after day the young man attempts to hunt but cannot catch any game, his soft heart hindering his ability to hunt. His father is so hungry, he cries and gnaws on the corner of a buffalo robe. In desperation, the young man goes to a nearby cattle farmer's field and kills one of his cows. As he runs home with the meat, the farmer chases him, and the young man accidentally kills him. The young man returns home with the meat to find his father has already died. The next morning he takes his mother to join the rest of their people and turns himself in. As he sits in his cell waiting to be hanged, he wonders who will meet him after death—Jesus or his father. And he is not afraid.

Analysis

This is the first story in the collection that is not autobiographical. The first-person narrator is not Zitkala-Ša but a young Christian Sioux man. Zitkala-Ša tells his story with sympathy, despite her distaste for Christianity.

She begins by describing his life as a teenager, before going away to study among white people. This glimpse at his earlier years shows the family he grew up with and the kind of future he anticipated. The narrator describes the father as a brave hunter and a well-respected man. The son seems to want to follow in his footsteps and have his choice among the eligible young women in the village. However, in the nine-year interim between this scene and the young man's return, both he and his place in the community have changed. The young man is a stranger in his own home because of his time among white people, his adoption of their style of dress, and most of all his conversion to Christianity. With a soft heart, he is no longer the man who was going to hunt buffalo and marry a young woman in the community. His new ways have lost him the respect of his people. He wasted his potential, in their eyes, and he has become a "soft-hearted" traitor. Had he been less rigid and

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

soft, or more amenable to beliefs other than his own narrow ones, and not offended the medicine man—and by extension his father—his situation might have been different, for it is the medicine man who leads the people against him.

There is a sense of bitter situational irony (in what happens is the opposite of what is expected to happen) in what happens to the narrator. He converts to Christianity, is a true believer, and follows the white man's rules. Yet by doing this, he eventually condemns himself to be killed by the white man. His death comes at the hands of a people who follow a creed that instructs "thou shalt not kill," but his conversion to this creed doesn't save him. The young man tries to do the right thing each step of the way, but hunger and desperation eventually drive him to commit a crime against a white rancher. The author might be asking readers to extend the irony to wonder whether a white rancher would have been condemned to death for stealing an Indian's meat and killing him. Yet the Christian Sioux was doomed to die whether or not he committed thievery. Either he and his family would have died from starvation or he would be hanged for thievery. The tragedy lies in his committing the crime too late to save his father, and, in a reversal of the situation, nothing would likely have happened to the rancher.

Part 2, The Trial Path

Summary

As a grandmother and granddaughter lie in a tepee at night, the grandmother tells the girl that the stars are the spirits of warriors. The girl muses aloud that the one they can see through the top of the tepee must be her grandfather. At this, the grandmother says it's the anniversary of the elder grandfather's death and explains that the girl had two grandfathers. To the girl's surprise, her grandmother tells her that two best friends fought over her, and the second husband killed the grandmother's first husband. The killer was then challenged by the dead man's family to ride a wild horse a certain distance. They promised to pardon him if he could complete the deed without the horse throwing and killing him. The man succeeded and became the grandmother's second husband. The granddaughter is surprised. They killed the horse, her grandmother explains, when the grandfather died. At the end of her tale, the grandmother looks over to find her granddaughter asleep and mutters in frustration that the girl didn't treat her story with enough sanctity.

Analysis

The previous story shifted the pattern of storytelling away from the autobiographical, and this story continues in that pattern. Zitkala-Ša tells the tale of a grandmother who reveals a surprising past to her granddaughter. Within the story, she introduces several Dakota traditions and customs. In the beginning, she uses the character of the grandmother to explain that the stars are the spirits of dead warriors. This explanation initiates the grandmother's reminiscence about her two husbands. The story also mentions two interesting customs. In one, the victim's family accepts the killer after he succeeds at a task. This custom seems a way of leaving the punishment to fate, as opposed to simply choosing one for the killer. The grandmother then marries her first husband's killer presumably because he has been accepted into the family in place of the dead man.

The killing of the horse at the funeral of the grandfather is another custom. This may not be widespread or traditional, but the medicine man gives his approval and sanctions the grandmother's decision to kill the horse. As the grandmother tells the granddaughter about this decision, she reveals sacred information in the form of the medicine man's words to her. Because of its sacred nature, the grandmother places great significance on speaking about it to her granddaughter. Therefore, the old woman is frustrated to find her granddaughter has fallen asleep and not heard her—a comment perhaps on what is happening to the Dakota way of life and the passing on of the old stories.

Part 2, A Warrior's Daughter

Summary

A proud and generous warrior beats out a rhythm and watches happily as his eight-year-old daughter dances to it. At this time, a man who is the freed slave of the father returns to the village and joins them on the grass. The girl, Tusee, calls him uncle. She will dance her first dance at the gathering that night, and in honor of that occasion she asks her uncle to catch a wild pony

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

from her father's herd to give as a gift.

Time goes by, and Tusee is older. In her tepee she sews beads while a young man talks to her. He tells her he is leaving with a war party and has told her father he wants to marry her. In response, her father told the young brave he must return with an enemy scalp if he wants to marry Tusee. With other women, Tusee rides out on her father's warhorse with the party, following behind the warriors. When they attack the enemy camp, the enemy take her lover. That night Tusee, disguised as an old woman, sneaks into the enemy camp, lures away her lover's captor, and kills him. Then she cuts her lover free after everyone has gone to sleep. When he cannot walk, she carries him back to their camp.

Analysis

Zitkala-Ša tells the story of a woman who takes on a traditionally male role, rescuing her lover instead of playing the maiden-in-distress. The story begins by following a well-used traditional form, with a dutiful daughter who doesn't wish to go against her father in choosing her lover. The formula of the male who must successfully complete a deed or quest to win the daughter's hand appears frequently across most cultures. "A Warrior's Daughter" follows this popular form until the young warrior is captured.

At this point, the story takes an interesting turn. The dutiful daughter, Tusee, becomes the rescuer of the warrior. Not only does she rescue him, but also she accomplishes the very task her father set for the young warrior. The story becomes one of her strength, intelligence, and bravery instead of the prowess of the young man. The story of the young woman rescuing her male lover through strength and bravery appears occasionally in traditional storytelling across other cultures, but it is rare. One example of such a story is the tale of Tam Lin, a ballad from the British Isles. In this story a young pregnant woman rescues her lover from the faerie queen by pulling him off his horse and holding onto him through terrifying transformations. In both stories the marriage of the lovers is unimportant. The primary focus is on the rescuer. "The Warrior's Daughter" ends not with a marriage, but with Tusee developing extraordinary strength and carrying her lover back to camp.

Part 2, A Dream of Her Grandfather

Summary

The granddaughter of a great medicine man grows up to become an activist for her people. Her grandfather, too, worked for indigenous people's rights in his time until he became ill and died in Washington, D.C. While the granddaughter is in Washington doing welfare work, she has a dream in which she returns to her lodgings to find a cedar chest waiting for her. The chest was sent by her grandfather, even though he had since passed on. Inside the chest are not the medicine bags and other tools she expects, but a vision. In the vision are a camp full of people and a village crier on a horse. He tells the people to "rejoice ... and see the new day dawning," adding "Help is near." The dream fills the granddaughter with hope.

Analysis

Told by a third-person narrator, this story contains some parallels to Zitkala-Ša's own life, as she too moved to Washington, D.C. to work for her people's benefit. The narrative paints a picture of parts of the Dakota way of life, including little details like the grandfather's beaded medicine bag decorated with porcupine quills. Zitkala-Ša's choice to focus most of the story on the granddaughter's dream also indicates the cultural significance assigned to dreams. Indeed, this dream carries great weight for the protagonist, who sees it as a harbinger of hope and change for her people. For contemporary readers, however, this story has an edge of tragedy to it and ends on a note of dramatic irony (in which the reader knows something the audience does not) because that hope never was fulfilled for the indigenous peoples.

Part 2, The Widespread Enigma Concerning Blue-Star

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Woman

Summary

Blue-Star Woman, an elderly Sioux, is near starving and making fry-bread with some lard she was given. An orphan, she can produce no proof of family to register with a tribal association and receive her allotment of land. A pair of con men appear at her dwelling and offer to help her in exchange for half her government land and money. She reluctantly agrees, seeing no other option to obtain these.

Later, Sioux Chief High Flier learns of Blue-Star Woman's enrollment on his tribe register. He doesn't know her and is upset at her enrollment because the tribe doesn't have enough land to go around. He writes a letter to a prominent American woman he knows. On his way to the post office, however, he realizes the letter will do no good, and so he burns it. On his return journey the Indian police approach him and inform him he is being arrested as a troublemaker. In prison Chief High Flier grapples with his despair until he has a vision of the Statue of Liberty. The vision gives him hope and allows him to wait out his prison term with patience and dignity. When he is released, Chief High Flier finds his son and many other people waiting to escort him home. Included in this crowd are the two con men. Chief High Flier's son admits he gave them half of High Flier's land in exchange for securing his release.

Analysis

There are two protagonists in "The Widespread Enigma Concerning Blue-Star Woman." For the first part of the story, Blue-Star Woman is the central character. For the second part it's Chief High Flier. In her story, Zitkala-Ša illustrates the desperate circumstances of the Sioux people and of Native Americans generally. Blue-Star Woman and Chief High Flier represent two honest, struggling people of whom the system takes advantage. They are initially victims of colonization, the U.S. government selling their land to white settlers and doling out small portions back to its original inhabitants. Colonization brings with it acculturation and a new set of unfamiliar rules by which Native Americans must live, forcing them to adapt to a system completely foreign to them and at odds with their beliefs and way of life. Because the colonists' systems contradict their social and religious codes, Native Americans often must make painful decisions. When they try to play by the rules, as this story demonstrates, they are often swindled or ignored. Chief High Flier writes a letter in the hope of having his struggle heard but destroys it upon the realization that no one in power cares.

Acculturation leads to the erasure of cultural traditions and produces characters like the con men and the Indian police. They play by white rules and learn how to work the system, leaving their traditional codes of ethics behind. As a result, there is no recourse or accountability available within the tribe to deal with such characters. They take power from the system and use it for their own gain, unconcerned about the damage they do to others. Zitkala-Ša's story illustrates the hopelessness and injustice of this situation. This is not a story with a hopeful ending. Instead, the author allows a moment of hope as Chief High Flier is released from prison but then steals it away again with the revelation that Chief High Flier was doubly scammed.

Part 2, America's Indian Problem

Summary

Zitkala-Ša begins with examples of explorers and plunderers of the Americas, such as (Christopher) Newport and (Hernando) DeSoto, who deceived the Native people that embraced and welcomed them. The government, she explains, treats indigenous people as "legal victims," not rightful inhabitants of the land. The solution, Zitkala-Ša insists, is to give the Native peoples legal rights and citizenship, instead of treating them as wards of the state. She outlines how getting rid of "piecemeal legislation" will help clear the way for more constructive legislation and dealings with Native Americans. She details a series of reports made to Congress that were subsequently filed away in a dark corner, never made accessible to the public or even included in official reports.

Zitkala-Ša argues that the crux of the problem lies in the legal status of the Native American, which is not citizenship. Because Native people have had no citizenship status, they also have had no say in their treatment or governance. The government, she points out, has provided only "sham

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

protection" to indigenous people. Claiming to provide protection by holding Native land in trust, it can then turn around and profit from the resources on that land. Zitkala-Ša points out that the government still actually owes Native Americans millions of dollars, and opportunities still exist to fulfill some of its promises. She insists the government has many precedents to follow in the form of "private corporate trusts that have been mismanaged," which could be applied to the mismanagement and fraudulent treatment of Native Americans and their land.

Analysis

The final piece in Zitkala-Ša's *American Indian Stories* collection is not a story at all, but an essay in support of indigenous rights. It is an account of attempts made to demonstrate to the U.S. government how its dealings with the Native Americans are unfair and uncoordinated. It is a fitting final entry in a collection of stories, both autobiographical and otherwise, that seek to illustrate the dispossession and injustice faced by indigenous peoples in the Americas. Zitkala-Ša shows, in this essay, that the U.S. government has deliberately ignored repeated attempts to improve the Native American situation and the laws around their society and land.

At one point early in the essay, Zitkala-Ša calls for the help of "the women of America." Without context, this could be a confusing statement. It also recalls Chief High Flier's hopeful vision in the previous story, in which he sees a mass of American women led by the Statue of Liberty. Both instances allude to Zitkala-Ša's work with the General Federation of Women's Clubs. As a member, Zitkala-Ša was able to create an Indian Welfare Committee and influence the shift of indigenous people's status.

Zitkala-Ša is highly vocal about government collusion in the painful state of Native American culture and community, arguing vehemently about both neglect and exploitation. Her proposed solutions include a complete overhaul of the various disjointed and meaningless laws dictating indigenous rights and of the pressing need to grant citizenship to Native Americans. The government has created a system "to repress rather than to provide adequate means for justly dealing with a large population which had no political rights." This system and the lack of legal rights are the current sources of injustice to Native peoples.

Part 3, The Indian's Awakening–The Red Man's America

Summary

The Indian's Awakening

In the first stanza of Zitkala-Ša's prose poem, the speaker alludes to painful experiences in Indian boarding school, asserting even Christ could not cure people of "old race-problems." In the third stanza the speaker voices despair for her people. The speaker is "a wanderer now," living between cultures but belonging to neither. Midway through the poem, the speaker moves from a feeling of faith lost to a jubilant sense of faith regained, a connection with God/The Great Spirit, and a sense of unity throughout humankind. As the stanzas progress, the speaker embarks on a journey of faith, culminating in the rebirth of a village of people who had died. A spirit explains that souls are eternal, and the speaker's soul returns to the Great Spirit on a steed from the spirit world, leaving a message of hope: "Gift of Life, pray waste not in wails!"

A Year's Experience in Community Service Work Among the Ute Tribe of Indians

In the autumn of 1915, volunteers met weekly, their first project being to sew warm garments for the tribe's elderly population who could no longer sew and had no money to buy ready-made clothing. The Society of American Indians donated most of the materials for sewing. The volunteers also created a "rest-room" and served meals for the many Indians who came from far away to the government office on Mondays. Many materials for this space also were donated by the Society of American Indians. In the spring the volunteers redirected their efforts and organized monthly social and instructive meetings, discussing topics of significance. Zitkala-Ša refers to her community center work as performing part of "a divine obligation" to care for and honor one's parents and as doing

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

her duty for "the uplift of our kinsmen."

The Red Man's America

"The Red Man's America" is Zitkala-Ša's version of the song "America," in which each verse is reworked to highlight the suffering of America's indigenous population. In the first stanza, she emphasizes the word *our* in "land where our fathers died." This emphasis points to the slaughter and tragic deaths of so many Native people, especially at the hands of white colonization. The second stanza asserts the "red man" is not free. The third stanza calls on politicians and Congress to break their silence and grant justice to the Native Americans. The fourth and final stanza calls on God to protect the human rights of the indigenous people and grant them their home, which is their birthright.

Analysis

These three pieces represent a variety of Zitkala-Ša's writing. The first piece is poetry, the second a documentation of community service work among tribal peoples, and the third a satirical reworking of the patriotic song "America." "The Indian's Awakening" is a prose poem, a type of poetry that doesn't use traditional line breaks and looks more like paragraphs on a page. The movement of this poem parallels Zitkala-Ša's own life. The first stanza has echoes of her early days at boarding school. The line " A hand cut my hair; my robes did deplete" alludes to Zitkala-Ša's experience of having her hair forcibly cut and having to wear the clothing of white culture. The next stanza describes her despair and loss of faith during the time after boarding school, as she realizes what the U.S. government is doing to her people. Then, like Zitkala-Ša's own transformation, the speaker describes a regaining of faith and visions of the salvation of indigenous tribes. She even uses the word *mosaic* in reference to the different races being part of one mosaic, as she does in her essay "The Great Spirit."

Zitkala-Ša's detailing of her community work among the Ute tribe has two purposes. On one hand, it presents to the public the work she and her fellow volunteers are doing. She describes the positive impact of that work, allowing her to illustrate its dire importance. The other purpose is to inform the public of the difficult circumstances of indigenous people at the time. Not only does she describe a troubling situation of extreme poverty and cultural struggles, but she also reveals the problematic role of the government in indigenous people's lives. The government office provides no rest room, or lounge, for the people coming to take care of their business, forcing women and children to stand outside all day in the snow. Her portrait of life on the Ute reservation is not sugar coated. She means to convey the painful details of the situation to the public. In addition, Zitkala-Ša uses this report to enforce the duty that young indigenous people have to their elderly and the continuation of their culture.

Zitkala-Ša's rewriting of "America" as "The Red Man's America" is an exercise in verbal irony (in which what is said is the opposite of what is meant). She takes the traditional lyrics and twists them to highlight the situation of the indigenous people of America. The lyrics point at how the rights, liberties, freedoms, and joys expressed in the original song have been stripped from the original inhabitants of American soil. For instance, the third verse of the original song calls for people to lift their voices in a song of freedom. Zitkala-Ša's lyrics instead ask Congress to speak up and grant true freedom to the Indian. In this stanza she also mentions two specific bills introduced to Congress at the time. "Lane's Bill" refers to a bill introduced by Senator Harry Lane to abolish the Bureau of Indian Affairs. Senator Lane was a staunch supporter of rights for Native Americans and opposed abuse at the hands of the U.S. government. Gandy's Bill sought to make peyote use illegal. Zitkala-Ša saw this legislation as a much-needed federal protection from a dangerous narcotic, thus her proclamation "let Gandy's Bill awake All people."

Part 3, Chipeta, Widow of Chief Ouray with a Word About a Deal in Blankets–Editorial Comment (July–September 1918)

Summary

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Chipeta, Widow of Chief Ouray with a Word About a Deal in Blankets

Zitkala-Ša visits Chipeta, a respected Ute widow, to consult about peyote use. She explains to Chipeta that peyote is a narcotic and can be dangerous. Chipeta's brother replies the government has sent them letters explaining that whiskey and gambling are bad, so they banned these in the tribe. However, they will not stop peyote use until they receive a similar notification. Zitkala-Ša then writes calling for federal action to this effect.

She then narrates a story she heard about Chipeta sometime after their meeting. The government decided to send her a gift to thank her for her and her husband's service in helping white settlers. Zitkala-Ša thought the gift would be something significant, like water rights or title to the land of their reservation. However, the gift was shawls from their own trading store, and the bill was sent to the government office on the Ute reservation. On receiving the shawls, Chipeta sent a valuable Navajo blanket, which she paid for personally, to the sender of the shawls.

A Sioux Woman's Love for Her Grandchild

In this 10-stanza prose poem, the speaker describes a grandmother watching her happy grandchild play on the prairie. The girl is seven years old, and her mother died in childbirth. The grandmother wonders how quickly children grow from babies to creatures who run and play. As dark clouds begin to creep over the prairie, the grandmother looks for her granddaughter, who has disappeared. Men come to tell her an army is advancing and she must flee without her grandchild. As the tribe flees, the grandmother stays where she is, choosing death over leaving without the child.

Editorial Comment (July–September 1918)

In this essay Zitkala-Ša describes the meeting of many tribes at the annual Society of American Indians conference in Pierre, South Dakota. The conference takes place during World War I, which is the main topic of discussion. Zitkala-Ša supports the fight to defend democracy. She points out, however, that America should show the same passion for democracy closer to home as they do abroad. In other words, the U.S. government must honor their dedication to democracy by listening to the voices of Native Americans.

Analysis

In her first essay, Zitkala-Ša describes the painful situation of a respected Ute elder. Chipeta's story epitomizes the situation of many indigenous people in the United States. Chipeta and her husband were instrumental in aiding and saving the lives of many white settlers in the region. They treated the settlers as neighbors and helped them unselfishly and compassionately. In response, the government not only waits a long time to thank the couple, after Chipeta's husband has died, but the gift they send is beyond insulting.

The gift of Ute trading-store shawls to a Ute elder is problematic in several ways. First, the gift is a pittance compared to what Chipeta has done and to the needs of her people. Zitkala-Ša imagines more appropriate and meaningful gifts, including the title to the Ute land. However, these gifts would be costly and inconvenient to the government, whereas shawls are cheap and require little effort to give. Second, that the Ute tribe ultimately paid for their own gift is offensive and unjust. If this incident were simply government oversight, it only proves Zitkala-Ša's often repeated point that the government's method of dealing with Native Americans is convoluted, conflicted, ineffective, and unjust.

Interspersed with Zitkala-Ša's essays and descriptions of meetings and conferences is another passionate poem about the Sioux people. In "A Sioux Woman's Love for Her Grandchild" Zitkala-Ša's intention seems to be to illustrate a grandmother's bravery, love, and self-sacrifice. The grandmother loves her granddaughter so fiercely that she refuses to leave without her despite imminent danger. The grandmother is depicted in contrast to the other members of the tribe who flee in fear. In the final image of the poem, the grandmother is silhouetted against a backdrop of dust and storm clouds, leaning on her cane. On a broader level, the scene is an illustration of an indigenous elder's bravery in the face of oncoming white colonizers whose arrival spells doom not only for the grandmother and her granddaughter but also for older and younger generations of indigenous people and their way of life.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

"Editorial Comment" opens a window of insight into Zitkala-Ša's and other indigenous people's viewpoints regarding World War I. Zitkala-Ša seems both to support the war and to find it deeply problematic. She points out that America fights a war abroad in the defense of democracy while ignoring injustices at home. She insists "as America has declared democracy abroad, so must we consistently practice it at home." At this time, in 1918, the government did not even consider Native Americans citizens of the United States. Despite their status as the original inhabitants of the land, they were not granted legal citizenship until 1924. Zitkala-Ša states if an Indian "is good enough to fight for American ideals he is good enough for American citizenship now." The "now" on the end of this sentence emphasizes the long-delayed justice due to her people.

Part 3, Indian Gifts to Civilized Man–Editorial Comment (Winter 1919)

Summary

Indian Gifts to Civilized Man

Zitkala-Ša describes the harmonious relationship between indigenous Americans and the natural world. This relationship, in turn, led to the perfection of two important crops: corn and potatoes. Because of World War I, there is a need to conserve wheat to send overseas, and people are encouraged to eat more corn and potatoes in its absence. Zitkala-Ša points to the vital role Native Americans have played in the war effort for this reason. Because of their development of these critical crops, the United States can conserve food. Additionally, thousands of young Native American men joined the army. Proportionate to the few hundred thousand indigenous people who are left, this is a huge percentage.

Secretary's Report in Brief

Zitkala-Ša outlines the purpose and duties of the Society for American Indians. One of the society's goals is to inform the general public of matters important to Native Americans. Zitkala-Ša notes the requisitioning of one of the main government Indian schools by the military for war purposes. She includes copies of correspondence between herself and the Third Assistant Secretary of War regarding this repurposing. In her letter she urges the secretary to consider commandeering another institution in place of the Carlisle School, but the secretary responds this is not possible. She then addresses the Native American population, urging them to be proactive in demanding their human rights.

Editorial Comment (Winter 1919)

Zitkala-Ša wrote this essay in the winter of 1919, as peace talks were taking place in Europe after the conclusion of World War I. Zitkala-Ša lauds the importance of democracy and the peace talks at which so many nations and peoples are represented and their voices heard. To this end, she asks who will represent the Native American at those peace talks, and when will the voices of the original American be heard?

Analysis

In all three articles, Zitkala-Ša has one overarching purpose: to reach the general American public to build sympathy for Native Americans and their situation. Each article was written against the backdrop of World War I, in which many Native American men fought and died alongside white Americans. She points to first lady Edith Wilson's use of indigenous names for warships as a recognition of the Native Americans' importance to the war effort. But her purpose in emphasizing the critical roles of indigenous people in the war is also to highlight the injustice of their situation. Her account is, in effect, a tool to reveal that Native Americans do not have U.S. citizenship. She points out that indigenous people ask "for a very simple thing—citizenship in the land that was once [their] own—America." This is a powerful statement about the situation of indigenous people at the time. They had no citizenship in their own country, and the U.S. government patronized them with a mixture of willful neglect and empty promises.

Curiously, Zitkala-Ša's secretarial report reveals her support of indigenous children being educated in the traditionally white system. Although her other articles and essays suggest her support of Native American children being educated in this way, none is so openly explicit as this. Her main goal appears

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

to be the integration of indigenous children into public schools so that they enjoy the same benefits guaranteed to all white children.

However, she also seems to support government boarding schools, despite her own negative experiences. Her letter requesting the continuation of the Carlisle Indian School is somewhat surprising, considering her personal experience as a teacher there. Zitkala-Ša was openly critical of the school during her time there, disagreeing with its harsh methods and eradication of the indigenous culture of its students. Yet she clearly sees some benefit in the school and its amenities, because she begs the war secretary to keep it functioning.

Part 3, America, Home of the Red Man–Letter to the Chiefs and Headmen of the Tribes

Summary

America, Home of the Red Man

A white man asks a Native American woman—the secretary of the Society of American Indians—about a service pin she is wearing. She explains her husband is a member of the Sioux Nation and a volunteer in the army. The stranger replies, "I knew when I first saw you that you must be a foreigner." Zitkala-Ša refers to this sentence as an "amazing speech." She details the many contributions of Native Americans to the war effort, which include donating $12 million to the Liberty Loans program. She next relates an incident of an elderly grandmother giving all her money to the war effort and a brave soldier who kept fighting despite multiple injuries. At the end of the article, Zitkala-Ša refers to several magazine articles about Native people. In particular, she asks about the problem of "paternalism," which an article in *National Geographic* claims does not exist in America. After the woman provides all this information for the traveler, he leaves "lest he be snared into subscribing for one or all of these publications."

The Coronation of Chief Powhatan Retold

Zitkala-Ša tells a condensed version of the crowning of Chief Powhatan by Captain Newport. Newport and his men travel to bring gifts to the chief, including a royal robe and crown. Chief Powhatan is not impressed by the kingly gifts and has to be convinced to let Newport conduct a coronation. He is so resistant to the coronation that they must eventually trick him into it.

Letter to the Chiefs and Headmen of the Tribes

Zitkala-Ša draws the attention of various chiefs and headmen to the issues of the English language and the ownership of their lands. First, she tries to persuade her readers of the importance of learning English to communicate more effectively across tribes and with white people. She advises them of educational opportunities now available. Second, she urges tribal leaders not to sell off their lands, because she foresees a day when the Indians will have no land left to call their own.

Analysis

The essay "America, Home of the Red Man" was written about the same time as the previous "Editorial Comment," both in Winter 1919 after World War I had ended and peace talks were in progress. Zitkala-Ša relates the incident in which the Native American woman—herself, for she was secretary of the Society of American Indians at the time—is thought to be a "foreigner" to illustrate how much of the white world views indigenous people. Native Americans are somehow foreigners on their own ancestral land, while the white man and colonizers assume they are its rightful inhabitants, though they have come from foreign countries. Zitkala-Ša therefore makes the point that it is offensive to presuppose anyone who does not have white skin is a foreigner.

Additionally, the author goes into detail to illustrate the magnitude of the Native American contribution to the war effort. From food and soldiers to large amounts of money, indigenous people gave extensively to support a fight for

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

democracy. It is significant the Native Americans gave so much, when they had so little, in support of a government that has yet to treat them justly. Zitkala-Ša insists democracy is a value held by Native people long before it became the standard in the United States and Europe.

She points out this longstanding democratic tradition in her essay about Chief Powhatan, in which she illustrates an indigenous leader's distrust of kingship and its implications. His suspicion of the coronation gifts of robe and crown is symbolic of his suspicion of the power they represent. Chief Powhatan, according to Zitkala-Ša, represents a chief who led his people democratically and did not dictate how they should live. That he must be tricked into the coronation is an omen of the way white colonizers will deal with Native Americans in the future—deceit and dominance. Chief Powhatan seems to sense this when he asks, "Are you come to trifle with me and to kill?"

Zitkala-Ša's approach to her people's place in the changing world is curiously mixed. At times, she is enthusiastically supportive of keeping alive traditions, such as the treatment of elders or hospitality to guests. Yet at other times she argues that traditions should be changed, such as the use of peyote. When she writes to the tribal leaders, she advocates for the adoption of English and the white education system, while in the same breath pointing out the folly of European houses. This ambivalence can be explained by considering Zitkala-Ša a survivalist. Although she champions the survival of indigenous people and important traditions, she also encourages adoption of white education and language to help tribes survive as America changes.

Part 3, Editorial Comment (Spring 1919)–Address by the Secretary-Treasurer, Society of American Indians Annual Convention

Summary

Editorial Comment (Spring 1919)

Zitkala-Ša explains the situation of the Black Hills claim, in which the U.S. government broke a treaty with the Sioux over a land claim. She argues that the Sioux people and other Native Americans must be given citizenship and access to legal recourse for their complaints. She points to a case in which Congressman Hastings, himself of Cherokee blood, argued that the Osage tribe should be able to hire and choose their own legal counsel because an attorney appointed by the government would be responsible to the government and thus unable to act freely on behalf of his clients.

The Bureau of Indian Affairs is, in Zitkala-Sa's opinion, a major obstacle to Native Americans acquiring justice. She gives examples of the BIA turning down blacksmith training for Ute Indians. In another example of BIA mismanagement, the Bureau leases Ute grazing land to white ranchers for a substantial sum of money. In the U.S. Treasury a large amount of Ute funds could be put toward stock to graze this land instead of having it leased out, but the Bureau has not encouraged this alternative.

Editorial Comment (Summer 1919)

After praising the work and bravery of the returned Native American soldiers, Zitkala-Sa brings the idea of bravery home, saying a life "of reservation exile may require as much heroism, if not more, to live than it did to die in actual battle." She adds that "every Indian, who stands firmly on his own feet, for ... justice and freedom, is ... a living hero in the skirmishes of daily life!"

Zitkala-Ša then reveals that a founding member of the Society for Indian Affairs bequeathed the society $3000 upon her death. She also describes the lecture tour of the SIA president, Dr. Charles Eastman. Advocating citizenship for Indians, Dr. Eastman made a successful tour around various towns and cities, but the Bureau of Indian Affairs refused to let him speak on Indian reservations. Zitkala-Ša points out the injustice of the prohibition and reiterates her stance on fair and democratic treatment for Native Americans.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

An Indian Praying on the Hilltop

In her prayer to the Great Spirit, Zitkala-Ša is positive and hopeful. She doesn't ask for anything but instead extends a prayer of gratitude and rejoicing. Despite "dreadful dreams," she sees justice in the Native Americans' future.

Address by the Secretary-Treasurer, Society of American Indians Annual Convention

This essay is the written version of Zitkala-Ša's address at the Society of American Indians convention. She claims it is honorable to work and to adapt to new ways of living and working. "Consciousness," Zitkala-Ša insists, is a gift from God and must be put to use. She urges people not to be intimidated by English or its difficulty but to do their best to speak their hearts. After urging her audience to be proud of their work, their heritage, and themselves, she cautions against passivity or timidity: "We are rational beings. Let us develop our powers by thinking and acting for ourselves." From here she urges her audience to organize, to unite as a voice for their people. Finally, she explains that the magnitude of her work and lack of help have impeded her from keeping up to date on accounts.

Analysis

Zitkala-Ša is outspoken in her criticism of the Bureau of Indian Affairs. In earlier essays, she argues that the bureaucracy, which handles the status and issues of Native Americans, is convoluted and harmful. She calls for the abolition of the Bureau because she sees how it mismanages Native American affairs and makes decisions against the people's best interests. Often, Zitkala-Ša points out, the BIA goes so far as to intentionally subvert the interests they are supposed to protect. In one case, opportunities offered to Ute youth never reach them because the BIA doesn't inform them of educational opportunities. In another instance, the head of Zitkala-Ša's organization tours around the United States arguing the case for Native American citizenship. Despite widespread positive responses from many nonindigenous people in a variety of cities and towns, the Bureau bans him from entering reservations. Zitkala-Ša paints a vivid and startling picture of government-backed repression of Native Americans. In her estimation, the Bureau is nothing more than a tool of the U.S. government to keep tribal people ignorant and deprived of official power or rights.

According to Zitkala-Ša, the BIA is indeed a major obstacle to Native American justice and freedom. Having written this article just after the end of World War I, she points to the Native Americans who served in the war and fought for a country that refuses to grant them citizenship. In response to the BIA's willful neglect of tribal people, she states passionately, "This is not the democracy for which our soldiers fought and died!"

One critical right indigenous people lack without citizenship is the availability of legal recourse. They cannot take anyone to court, nor can they vote or file formal legal action against a person or institution that has done them wrong. This exclusion extends to an inability to apply to the Supreme Court to right wrongs or uphold broken treaties. Zitkala-Ša implies the BIA itself could often be a target for legal action if tribal people could get legal representation. This is why it is so problematic that the only legal representation allowed to them is a lawyer whom the Bureau appoints. She uses the Black Hills claim and Congressman Hastings's petition as an example of the problem of having either no representation or one biased lawyer.

Zitkala-Ša's prayer and her speech at the annual Society of American Indians convention both are expressions of hope and inspiration, the primary theme of her speech being the importance of different tribes organizing into a unified front. She tries to inspire and motivate her audience at the convention to take an active role in demanding their human rights. In these pieces she does not focus on the wrongs done to indigenous people or on their suffering, but instead on what they must do to move forward. Zitkala-Ša calls for education and unity to help Native Americans of all tribal affiliations achieve citizenship and their basic constitutional rights.

Part 4, Side by Side–Iris of Life

Summary

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

Side by Side

This is Zitkala-Ša's winning speech from the Indiana State Oratorical Contest, in which she participated during her college years. She summarizes the history of the Anglo-Saxons' spread in Europe, then rewinds the recent history of America back before the coming of colonial powers, describing the "reverential awe" of nature and the Great Spirit in which the indigenous people lived. When the white men initially came in contact with the Native Americans, Zitkala-Ša relates, the local people welcomed them.

But Europeans introduced new ways and new vices: addictions to alcohol, broken treaties, aggression, and violence. With their homes, land, people, and entire way of life violated, "Is patriotism a virtue only in Saxon hearts?" Zitkala-Ša asks. When accused of cruelty, Indians were doing what they could to defend themselves and their entire way of life against the tyranny of invading colonizers. In comparing the deeds of Indians and Europeans, she explains that her people, "ignorant alike of Roman justice, Saxon law, and the Gospel of Christian brotherhood," acted only "in the fury of revenge" for what was done to them.

Zitkala-Ša asks her audience if the forced relocation of indigenous people marks their death. She wonders if they, the colonizers, will push them "almost to the farther sea" until nothing is left for them. At the end of her speech, she insists the only way forward is for both peoples to unite and move ahead together.

A Ballad

"A Ballad" is a lengthy narrative poem that follows Winona and Osseolo. The two characters are in love, Winona referring to Osseolo as "her heart's king." Winona fears the "moody owl," a bad omen, and begs Osseolo not to go into battle. Osseolo's father commands him, however, and he leaves on Winona's horse. One of the members of the tribe betrays Osseolo, and Winona's horse is killed. The enemy takes Osseolo prisoner, but he escapes while the enemy is celebrating their victory.

Iris of Life

In this short poem, Zitkala-Ša writes hopefully of moments that "wear away" selfishness. Actions that come from a place of honesty and sincerity create these moments, and "good deeds" inspire more goodness.

Analysis

"Side by Side" is a speech that indicates the foundation of Zitkala-Ša's approach to her later activism. In a rational but passionate tone, she uses history as the launching point for the rest of her ideas. Instead of simply demanding justice for past wrongs, she appeals to her audience for empathy, arguing for unity in working for a greater human cause. The combination of passion and reason, the precise and imaginative language, and the effectiveness of the historical analysis leave no doubt in readers' minds why this speech won the oratorical prize.

In addressing the claims of Native American violence toward white colonizers, Zitkala-Ša insists it is no surprise that Native Americans would fight back, for they loved the land and way of life the colonizers took from them. When asking the troubling question "Is patriotism a virtue only in Saxon hearts?" she emphasizes that Native Americans fought for their homeland and were no less "patriotic" than white soldiers fighting for theirs. When the government claims Native Americans have been "cruel" or inhumane toward white colonists, Zitkala-Ša asserts, "The White Man has been the witness and the judge." In other words, this claim is one-sided. Her final comments indicate that as early as 1898, when the speech was delivered, Zitkala-Ša understood there was no going back and the only way ahead was to adopt white man's ways and attain equal status in a united nation.

The tone of Zitkala-Ša's two poems following this speech also is one of inspiration, full of hope and zeal. Zitkala-Ša wrote all three pieces during her youth, but they pave the way for her later writing. The impassioned hope with which she believes in the human spirit is evident here and continues to pervade her life's work.

Part 4, A Protest Against the Abolition of the Indian Dance–Americanize the First

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

American

Summary

A Protest Against the Abolition of the Indian Dance

The author describes a man hacking ice from the river for water. At the same time as she observes him, she has a vision of nude sculptures in a modern art gallery, referring to them as a "marvelous imitation of God's own subtle works." The man at the river mutters about the immodesty of Native American dance, in which dancers wear paint and loincloths. The author believes clothing is a sign of false modesty, distracting attention from the body. Zitkala-Ša thinks further to herself that if Native American dance is immodest, the same is true of any dance. Moreover, it is one form of entertainment readily accessible to Native Americans. Finally, she expresses the belief that God made people to be "just as they are."

The Menace of Peyote

Zitkala-Ša directly addresses her concerns about indigenous people's widespread use of peyote. Historically, she points out, only a few tribes in Mexico used the cactus sparingly. However, the spread of peyote has led to issues of addiction among tribe members throughout the United States. It is so bad, she notes, even children use it. Zitkala-Ša insists peyote is a powerful narcotic to be regulated and discouraged, just as alcohol is.

Americanize the First American

In the first half of her essay, Zitkala-Ša discusses a catastrophic influenza epidemic two winters ago on the Pine Ridge Reservation. Because residents live far apart from one another, the distances make access to medical treatment difficult. But she also blames the two government physicians for not making the effort to tend as many of the sick as possible. The lack of treatment caused many deaths, leaving many Indian children orphaned. Zitkala-Ša then emphasizes the importance of Native American children, how they too have been displaced and devalued by the U.S. government. All children are immeasurably valuable, she insists, and indigenous children should be as valued as white children.

Analysis

Each of these pieces expresses Zitkala-Ša's views on a different issue facing Native American people. In "A Protest Against the Abolition of the Indian Dance," Zitkala-Ša creates the image of a man hacking at ice on a river. Oblivious to the rhythms of nature and the river as a living thing, the man symbolizes white men generally. This character contrasts with the indigenous person, who has lived for countless generations alongside the rhythms of the natural world. The man's mutterings represent the reasoning of the white world in degrading and banning Native American dance. However, in argument Zitkala-Ša points to dances of other cultures and notes how any one of them could seem ridiculous or immodest. Dance, in her opinion, is a simple and basic form of human expression that should not be restricted.

A vehement supporter of cultural traditions such as dance, Zitkala-Ša is nonetheless outspoken in her opposition to peyote because of the problem of addiction. Interestingly, Zitkala-Ša argues "Congress has been misinformed" about peyote's status as an ingredient in sacred rituals. Its use by tribes around the United States is more recent and the result of peyote trafficking, which the author seeks to have restricted. This explanation thus sheds light on what may seem to be contradictory thinking on the part of the author, as readers, like Zitkala-Ša's contemporaries, may have thought peyote use more traditional.

The epidemic referred to in "Americanize the First American" is the infamous pandemic of 1918–19, which caused more deaths than World War I, at least 50 million people throughout the world and 675,000 in the United States. If the government physicians had not been negligent, more people on the reservation might have survived. Though the illness ravaged the entire country, indigenous Americans were affected disproportionately to other communities in the United States. Reservations had four times the death rate from influenza as compared to large U.S. cities.

In the essay Zitkala-Ša continues her criticism of the Bureau of Indian Affairs. She points to several instances in which the Bureau again fails the people they should be speaking for and

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

aiding. When many Sioux die on the Pine Ridge Reservation as a result of untreated influenza, Zitkala-Ša points to a broken bureaucracy and laziness. She likens the "bitter ... cold" of the Dakota landscape to "human compassion ... unkindled." Additionally, Zitkala-Ša paints the BIA officials with some strong language regarding their use of power. She calls for an end to the "tyrannical powers of Government superintendents" who hold "a voiceless people" subservient to their own whims. The essay's title again underscores Native Americans' place in their Native land: victimized noncitizens with few rights and unworthy of the same attention given to citizens.

Part 4, Bureaucracy versus Democracy–A Dakota Ode to Washington

Summary

Bureaucracy versus Democracy

In her continued criticism of the Bureau of Indian Affairs, Zitkala-Ša points out that the government intended the BIA to be a temporary institution only. However, after 90 years in existence, it has grown into an unwieldy and, worse, a repressive organization: a "despotic-grown bureaucracy" that suppresses any attempts by indigenous people to claim their human rights. In a democracy, she suggests, such an organization that disenfranchises the law abiding and gives free reign to the lawless should be "relieved of its supervising" of orderly people and turn its attention to restraining those who menace "the liberty and property of the Indians." She further suggests letting indigenous people have a hand in their own government and setting up business schools for Indians. These actions, she claims, will help empower and enfranchise Native Americans.

A Dakota Ode to Washington

At the meeting of the Seven Council Fires of the Dakota people, the elders choose a young Yankton Dakota woman to take a message to a gathering of Americans in Washington. The messenger travels far via various means of transport to reach Washington, D.C. to present the elders' message. The words of their message praise and celebrate George Washington, first president of the United States. They sing his praises and remind their audience he chose the sacred eagle to be the symbol of the United States. The eagle is a symbol of "the conscious spirit of man" and the search for truth. The elders' message is to remember the meaning of the eagle and the message of truth and brotherhood it represents.

Analysis

Zitkala-Ša continues to discuss issues of bureaucracy, human rights, and indigenous traditions in these essays. She wrote each within a year, between 1921 and 1922, citizenship for Native Americans still two years away. The Bureau of Indian Affairs and Native American citizenship become primary missions for Zitkala-Ša during the last years of World War I and the years immediately following. Her tone remains a mixture of firmness, hopeful patriotism, and passionate criticism. In "Bureaucracy versus Democracy" the words "Americanize the first Americans" reappear. These words directly correspond to the title of a previous essay, "Americanize the First Americans." It almost seems as though the titles of "Bureaucracy versus Democracy" and "Americanize the First Americans" should have been reversed. Much of the content in "Bureaucracy versus Democracy" better fits the title and focus of "Americanize the First Americans."

It is important to note Zitkala-Ša, as an activist, does not merely present her audience with a list of wrongs and complaints. She applies to all Americans and to the U.S. government to correct the injustices done to Native Americans. Moreover, she offers her audience recommendations for how to improve the situation of the indigenous Americans. Her suggestions include citizenship, the dissolution of the outdated and pernicious Bureau of Indian Affairs, and educational opportunities. Zitkala-Ša does not throw out these suggestions flippantly. As she suggests and details in many of her essays, she spends considerable time visiting and listening to members of other tribes to understand their needs. She builds her recommendations to the government, mostly ignored, on years of research and firsthand experience. Her logic and humor shine through her writing and appeal to the common sense of her readers. She writes, "We insist upon our recognition by America as really normal and quite worth-while human beings." Despite the lighthearted tone, however, the situation is real and

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

serious, for the government and others frequently do not recognize indigenous people as normal or worthwhile.

Part 4, California Indian Trails and Prayer Trees–Heart to Heart Talk

Summary

California Indian Trails and Prayer Trees

Zitkala-Ša relates an ancient practice of California Indians in which new mothers graft trinkets or prayers onto the tips of young saplings. This practice is a solemn request for their babies to grow strong and straight toward the sky. Zitkala-Ša points to the beauty of this tradition and how many large redwoods and pines today are actually prayer trees. The cutting down of many of these trees and the killing of local Indians are a tragedy. Zitkala-Ša explains it is perhaps no surprise that a huge earthquake shook California, as Mother Earth's response to the destruction of her trees and her people. Natural disasters like this, many indigenous people believe, are the result of humans' "bad thoughts and deeds." Zitkala-Ša asserts most Native Americans hold life sacred, and the taking of life is a serious and terrible thing.

Lost Treaties of the California Indians

"Lost Treaties of the California Indians" continues the topics introduced in "Californian Indian Trails and Prayer Trees." California Indians may have fought grizzlies for bear skins but were generally peaceful and didn't war with other humans. When the Federal Commission asked leaders of the Native people in California to meet and sign treaties, they went in good faith. They signed away the bulk of their lands in exchange "for the promise of moneys, subsistence, clothing, supplies and educational advantages." The government guaranteed the documents proving that ownership of their leftover lands would be enough to protect them from white prospectors. This guarantee proved an empty promise, for with the gold rush came land-grabbers who offered only violence to the peaceful Native tribes, leaving them betrayed, defenseless, and stateless. The treaties of this time became known as the "Lost Treaties" of 1851 and 1852 because the government and settlers ceased to honor them.

The California Indians of Today

After 50 years the government releases the contents of the "Lost Treaties" to the public. With this release of information, Zitkala-Ša calls for people to speak up and demand justice for the "California Indian." The indigenous people of California are greatly reduced in number and have lost most of their lands and assets. Zitkala-Ša insists they first need justice to reinstate their tribal lands and some of what they lost in the treaties, for "before we may bestow charity we must first be just."

Heart to Heart Talk

Zitkala-Ša congratulates California Native Americans on some local victories, including public school access for children. She encourages them to stay connected to other tribes to work together for the common goals of human rights and justice for indigenous people, mentioning misfortunes of those in Oklahoma. Zitkala-Ša encourages the Native people of California to continue their good work.

Analysis

Written in 1922, these final essays in Zitkala-Ša's collection focus on the history and plight of the indigenous people of California. Zitkala-Ša's ability to write with hope and empathy despite the U.S. government's continuing refusals to address the unjust situation of the Native Americans is one of her superpowers. For more than 20 years she has continued to present Congress with recommendations, to call for support from the American people, and to encourage indigenous people to fight for their rights. Most of her essays and speeches contain words of inspiration and hope, despite the frustrating and seemingly endless battle she fights. She often surrounds fiercely critical language with words of inspiration or praise. This strategy has the effect of strengthening her arguments and keeping her speeches and essays from becoming vehicles solely for angry criticism. She urges her fellow Native Americans that every day when they "see the sun

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

rise in the sky" to be encouraged in their work, "no matter what obstacles ... appear to be."

In these writings Zitkala-Ša displays a decidedly pan-Indian approach to her activism. In previous essays as well she writes to encourage Native people of different tribes to unite and work for a common goal. The Society for American Indians (SAI), which Zitkala-Ša helped form and for which she served as secretary, was created in 1911. This was the first organization on the national level created to help and reach tribes around the United States. Along with the formation of the SAI grew the movement for "pan-Indianism," which held that Native people would be more effective in receiving justice if they acted as a unified whole. Zitkala-Ša writes, "It is clear to us all that Indians must think and act together." In her message to the Native Americans of California, she specifically encourages them to join the national forum of indigenous people working for their human rights.

“ Quotes

"Indian folklore, a study which so strongly suggests our near kinship with the rest of humanity."

— Narrator, Part 1, Preface

Here Zitkala-Ša refers to the study of Indian folklore, which reveals that Native American culture is deeply related to many other cultures in the considerable overlap of story types, archetypes, and morals. For Zitkala-Ša, this similarity proves the important point that Native Americans are not to be treated as strange or inferior, for they are no different from people belonging to any other human civilization, as they share common traditions.

"They were selfish tears. The Great Spirit does not heed them ever."

— Narrator, Part 1, Iktomi's Blanket

When Iktomi cries after he takes back his offering and finds his food gone as a result, his tears fall on deaf ears. The Great Spirit initially took pity on Iktomi because he gave an offering in the hope of receiving an answer to his prayers. However, once Iktomi chooses to be self-centered, his tears lose the power to evoke pity.

"She treated me as a dignified little individual as long as I was on my good behavior."

— Narrator, Part 2, Impressions of an Indian Childhood

Zitkala-Ša remembers how her mother treated her as a human being instead of a silly child. This treatment deeply affected Zitkala-Ša, who worked hard to behave in a dignified and responsible manner as a result, even when she was very young. However, as she implies in this statement, her mother treated her as a naughty child if she was in fact behaving like one.

"We were taken along an upward incline of wooden boxes, which I learned afterward to call a stairway."

— Narrator, Part 2, The School Days of an Indian Girl

Zitkala-Ša's childhood observation reveals how different her life was with her mother on the plains, as compared to her existence at school. When she first came to the boarding school, Zitkala-Ša knew almost nothing of her new environment. She had never seen stairs before and had no concept of what they were. She also had no language to describe them. This statement reveals the enormity of what Zitkala-Ša and her fellow students had to overcome in their new lives. They had no English and no concept of their new environment or expectations. As a result, they learned painfully, through mistakes and punishment.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

"In the process of my education I had lost all consciousness of the nature world around me."

— Narrator, Part 2, An Indian Teacher Among Indians

Zitkala-Ša has the realization that her life in the world of white Americans has completely disconnected her from her own culture. Her loss of connection with the natural world is representative of her general loss of connection with her home and her people's traditions and beliefs. As a student and then a teacher, she spends most of her life indoors, in stark contrast to her early childhood, which she spent outdoors running freely over the plains.

"It is an old ... custom among Indians to enter upon a subject slowly and not rush to discussion."

— Narrator, Part 3, Chipeta, Widow of Chief Ouray with a Word About a Deal in Blankets

Zitkala-Ša explains why she talks of other matters with Chipeta before coming to the actual subject of peyote use. This explanation reveals some cultural information about Native American practices. What Zitkala-Ša describes is considered an act of courtesy among the Ute and other indigenous people.

"As America has declared democracy abroad, so must we consistently practice it at home."

— Narrator, Part 3, Editorial Comment (July–September 1918)

In this passionate statement, written during World War I, Zitkala-Ša points out the hypocrisy of the United States in fighting a war for democracy overseas when they perpetuate injustice against the Native Americans at home. Although Zitkala-Ša supports the war, she also uses it to illustrate the importance of giving justice to the indigenous Americans.

"The Red man asks for a very simple thing—citizenship in the land that was once his own—America."

— Narrator, Part 3, Editorial Comment (Winter 1919)

Zitkala-Ša's statement gets right to the heart of her activism. In one sentence she summarizes the main problem facing Native Americans: they are not citizens in their native land. This injustice rings sharply throughout her work and especially in this statement. Native Americans gained citizenship five years after Zitkala-Ša wrote this editorial, but communities still struggle with a legacy of racism, cultural whitewashing, violence, and marginalization.

"Pocahontas was the first emissary of democratic ideas to caste-ridden Europe."

— Narrator, Part 3, The Coronation of Chief Powhatan Retold

In her essay imagining the coronation of Chief Powhatan, Zitkala-Ša envisions Pocahontas as an ambassador of democracy to a Europe still ruled by monarchs and with no concept of democracy. Pocahontas lived in the late 16th and early 17th centuries, and Zitkala-Ša suggests Pocahontas's people were already living in a democratic society well before white settlers developed the idea.

"I suggest that this bureau be ... assigned to ... restraining the unscrupulous citizens ... menacing the liberty ... of the Indians."

— Narrator, Part 4, Bureaucracy versus Democracy

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

In her proposal regarding the Bureau of Indian Affairs, Zitkala-Ša suggests the Bureau shift its focus from regulating Native Americans, who she argues are perfectly capable of handling their own affairs. Instead, the BIA should put its efforts into protecting Native Americans from outside forces that would take advantage of them, for they are being victimized across the board by white people and by their own. Zitkala-Ša asks the BIA to stop policing the victims and start policing the perpetrators.

Symbols

The Eagle

The eagle is a symbol of the qualities of bravery, honesty, and reverence to the Sioux tribe. In "A Dakota Ode to Washington," the narrator refers to the priests and priestesses as "keepers of the sacred eagle mysteries." The message they send to Washington, D.C. is that they honor President Washington by symbolically bestowing three eagle plumes upon him. In many of Zitkala-Ša's stories, the warriors wear eagle plumes as symbols of their bravery. It is an honor to receive an eagle feather, a mark of greatness of spirit or mind. In fact, the eagle sometimes represents the Great Spirit. Zitkala-Ša and the elders in "A Dakota Ode to Washington" see the use of the eagle as the symbol for the United States as an honor for the Native Americans.

The Crown

To Zitkala-Ša, the crown is symbolic of totalitarian rule, the opposite of democracy and all it stands for. In "The Coronation of Chief Powhatan Retold," Chief Powhatan is suspicious of the crown because of the kind of rulership it represents. As Zitkala-Ša explains, most tribal people live democratically, and the role of the chief or leader is not comparable to that of a king.

Readers may note a sense of situational irony (in which what is expected to happen is the opposite of what does happen) in the symbol of the crown. For the colonists, it represents the kind of despotic rulership they fled. However, in setting up their "democracy," those same colonists perpetuated the very same despotism—and worse—over the already democratic Native Americans.

Iktomi

Iktomi is a traditional trickster character and also an important figure in Dakota legends. Zitkala-Ša's choice to include and even feature his stories in her collection *Old Indian Legends*, however, has another level of meaning. Iktomi, as a selfish and at times clueless trickster character, also symbolizes the white colonizer. White colonists came to the Native Americans initially presenting a face of benevolence and then retracted their promises and offered violence instead. In this way, they are like Iktomi's trickster character. Zitkala-Ša sees white colonizers as completely self-involved, with no interest in indigenous people except for resources they might use. Perhaps Zitkala-Ša also understands how Iktomi's tales foreshadow the weaknesses of white society as well. Zitkala-Ša comes from a culture that recognizes the interconnected reality of humanity and nature. Therefore, it developed cultural traditions that showed respect for these things. To Zitkala-Ša's eye, white culture, like Iktomi, has no concern for other people or the natural world, simply wanting to take what it can to benefit itself.

Themes

Cultural Identity and Assimilation

Many of Zitkala-Ša's main concerns, thematically and personally, revolve around cultural identity and cultural assimilation. The term *cultural assimilation* specifically refers to the elimination of a minority culture by the dominating culture.

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.

In this case, Zitkala-Ša writes of government agencies' efforts to assimilate the various indigenous cultures of America. This assimilation is deeply connected with the concept of cultural identity; the government agencies' efforts to assimilate focus on removing aspects of cultural identity. Through her retelling of Dakota legends, stories about her school days, and various essays, Zitkala-Ša details different indigenous traditions and how authorities attempted to erase them, in the name of assimilation. Laws prohibiting Native traditions, such as traditional dance, were one way colonizing powers set about eradicating Native culture. Zitkala-Ša refers to this prohibition in the essay "A Protest Against the Abolition of the Indian Dance."

Missionary schools and government boarding schools also worked to assimilate indigenous children by forcing them to abandon their Native cultures. Most significant assimilationist tactics were pressures on children to convert to Christianity and to learn and speak only English instead of their indigenous languages. Consequently, the ban on indigenous languages created generations of indigenous people who couldn't speak the language of their parents and forgot the religious traditions of their tribes. Zitkala-Ša relates the story of having her hair forcibly cut when she went to a missionary boarding school. The event was traumatic for her because short hair signifies death or cowardice in her culture. With no knowledge of or respect for her cultural traditions, school authorities expected her to abandon familiar ways and thoughts to assimilate into white culture.

The other aspect of cultural identity Zitkala-Ša addresses in her writing is the problem of conflicted, rather than lost, identity. Zitkala-Ša and many children of her generation found themselves caught between the culture of their birth and the dominant white America. Because Zitkala-Ša went to boarding school and later to college, learned to read and write English, and began dressing like white women, she found herself growing distant from most of her roots. In *American Indian Stories* she describes a period of depression and loss of faith in the Great Spirit. Yet she also rejects Christianity and other traditions of the white world.

Bureaucracy and the Voiceless

A major theme of Zitkala-Ša's essays and speeches is the power of bureaucracy to silence the voices of indigenous people. Native Americans are disenfranchised by the bureaucracy put in place to manage them temporarily. The author points specifically at the Bureau of Indian Affairs, an institution she vehemently denounces. The Bureau, she writes, holds much responsibility for repressing and silencing the voices of her people. She cites cases in which the BIA withholds information about educational opportunities and in which it suppresses attempts at legal action. According to Zitkala-Ša, indigenous people who live on reservations "are held subservient to political appointees upon whom our American Congress confers discretionary powers." These "political appointees" could be any manner of officials assigned to deal with Native Americans. However, Zitkala-Ša is most outspoken about the officials of the BIA, which she views as a machine to keep her people voiceless.

Question of Human Rights

Again and again, Zitkala-Ša writes articles and speeches demanding human rights for indigenous people. She claims the government has denied her people basic human rights, and to keep its honor as a democracy, it must give justice to indigenous Americans. In particular, the right to citizenship and the right to vote are critical rights denied to Native Americans. Zitkala-Ša sees the absurdity in a situation in which the original Americans are not considered citizens of their own country. They have no right to legal recourse, no right to elect officials who will represent their concerns, and no right to any of those rights granted to U.S. citizens. She appeals to the government and the American people, insisting Native Americans deserve "recognition by America as really normal and quite worth-while human beings."

Copyright © 2019 Course Hero, Inc.